



## Report

# MSM and TGW Survey 2024 in Jamaica

To Client

**JAMAICA AIDS SUPPORT FOR LIFE (JASL)**

Prepared by

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On Behalf of

**A-Z Information Jamaica Limited**

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We trust that the report will be useful in helping to guide the National HIV/STI Control Program and all stakeholders to reduce the burden of HIV infection among MSM and TGW as well as reduce the stigma, abuse and violence so many of them face, and promote their wellbeing in the interest of all.



.....  
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CEO, A-Z Information Jamaica Ltd



.....  
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### ***List of Acronyms***

|          |                                                 |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------|
| AIDS     | Acquired Immune Deficiency Syndrome             |
| ART      | Antiretroviral Treatment                        |
| ARV      | Antiretrovirals                                 |
| ASHE     | The Ashe Company                                |
| BBS-LITE | Bio Behavioural Survey “lite”                   |
| BCC      | Behaviour change communication                  |
| BSS      | Bio-behavioural Surveillance Survey             |
| CDC      | Centers for Disease Control and Prevention      |
| CI       | Confidence Interval                             |
| ERTU     | Epidemiology Research and Training Unit         |
| HIV      | Human Immunodeficiency Virus                    |
| JASL     | Jamaica AIDS Support for Life                   |
| JN+      | Jamaica Network of Sero-positives               |
| MOHW     | Ministry of Health and Wellness - Jamaica       |
| MSM      | Men who have sex with men                       |
| NGO      | Nongovernmental organisation                    |
| PEP      | Post exposure prophylaxis                       |
| PrEP     | Pre-exposure prophylaxis                        |
| RDS      | Respondent Driven Sampling                      |
| SES      | Socio-economic status                           |
| STI      | Sexually Transmitted Infection                  |
| TGM      | Transgender Men                                 |
| TGW      | Transgender Women                               |
| TPPA     | Treponema pallidum particle agglutination assay |
| TRUST    | Toluidine Red Unheated Serum Test               |
| UNAIDS   | United Nations Joint Program on AIDS            |
| VL       | Viral Load                                      |
| WHO      | World Health Organisation                       |

## ***Executive Summary***

The MSM and TGW survey 2024 was conducted for the Ministry of Health and Wellness in Jamaica to estimate HIV and syphilis prevalence among MSM and TGW and assess progress in achieving prevention, treatment and care goals and related factors. Participants were recruited through NGO service sites offering prevention services and outreach activities including workshops offered by NGO and parish health staff. Men aged 16 years or older who had sex with a man in the past year and agreed to blood tests were eligible.

Between mid-July and early November 2024 459 MSM and 41 TGW were recruited. HIV prevalence among MSM was 27.0%, 95% CI 22.9% - 31.6% and among TGW was 53.7%, 95% CI 21.3% - 69.6%. Prevalence of ever having syphilis among MSM was 29.2%, 95% CI 21.3% - 37.0% and among TGW was 51.2%, 95% CI 35.2% - 57.2%. Both HIV and syphilis infection increased with age. HIV prevalence among MSM using pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP) was 12.0% compared with 32.3% among MSM not using PrEP. As many as 50.3% of MSM said that a health provider told them they had a STI in the past 12 months. Sexual risk behaviour was common with most participants (MSM 59.8%, TGW 70.8%) reporting 3 or more partners in the past 12 months and 35.5% of participants reporting ever receiving money for sex and 21% doing so within the past 6 months. 58.8% of MSM and 48.2% of TGW said they used a condom the last time they had sex with their main sex partner. Many participants suffered adverse life events as children and/or adults. Among MSM, a history of syphilis, ever being raped, homeless, in jail or prison, violently attacked by a sexual partner or not completing high school were all significantly associated with HIV infection on univariate analysis. One third of MSM (30.1%) were not comfortable telling anyone that they have sex with men and 24.4% of TGW and 17.7% of MSM had avoided seeking care because they were worried that they may be treated badly. Of 124 HIV positive MSM 114 (91.9%) were aware of their status, 110 (88.7%) were on treatment and 100 (80.6%) were virally suppressed. Of 22 HIV positive TGW 19 (86.4%) were aware of their status, 19 (86.4%) were on treatment and 15 (68.2%) were virally suppressed.

HIV prevalence among MSM and TGW remains high in Jamaica in 2024. We are failing to reduce the proportion of MSM and TGW getting HIV infected for the past 3 decades. A clear priority of the National HIV/STI Program must be to get many more MSM and TGW using PrEP at a young age. Nearly one third of participants tested positive for ever having syphilis (MSM 29.2%, TGW 51.2%) a known risk factor for HIV infection. Ready access to prompt diagnosis and treatment of syphilis and other STIs is essential. Experiencing adverse life events was associated with increased HIV prevalence as in the 2011 survey. The beating, verbal and sexual abuse that MSM and TGW receive as children and the high level of rape, homelessness and violence that they suffer as adults is unacceptable. Structural changes are needed to affirm the rights of MSM and TGW including changes in social and cultural norms and repeal or amendment of the Offences Against the Person Act.

### ***Specific Recommendations***

1. A clear priority of the National HIV/STI Program must be to get many more MSM and TGW using PrEP at a young age.
2. Bioline testing should be routinely offered to all MSM and young adults at Accident and Emergency departments of hospitals, inner city health centres and NGOs providing services to MSM and TGW.
3. A public education campaign to educate parents that beating and abusing children affects them negatively while praising good behaviour and expressing love for your child promotes self-esteem and appropriate behaviour.
4. Expand the early childhood stimulation program Reach Up to include all vulnerable children.
5. Establish more safe spaces for young MSM and TGW in schools and communities.
6. Train counselors in schools and communities to provide support and guidance to young MSM and TGW.
7. Develop training programs in areas such as personal growth and skill development to empower vulnerable MSM and TGW.
8. A system needs to be developed whereby persons seeking health services from NGO and public clinics are encouraged to present an ID to verify their name.
9. Continue the work to improve the quality of HIV treatment and care to MSM and TGW to achieve a higher proportion accessing anti-retroviral treatment and achieving viral load suppression.
10. Explore improving awareness of and access to post exposure prophylaxis (PEP).
11. Regional Health Authorities need to ensure that health staff have a suitable conference room to meet and conduct health promotion, prevention and training workshops and activities without the need to rent premises.
12. Support and advocate for continued funding to NGOs providing HIV prevention and other services and safe spaces for MSM and TGW.
13. Continue the work to reduce stigma and discrimination towards MSM and TGW in our health and other services.
14. Develop a closer relationship between the MOHW and Health Regions with private practitioners especially those who provide services for MSM and TGW.
15. Promote safe channels where MSM and TGW can report abuse, discrimination or violence and seek redress.
16. Challenge the religious communities to work more closely with, and provide services for, MSM and TG to better understand them and their needs.
17. Work to repeal or amend the Offences Against the Person Act of 1864 through the courts and through parliament.

## **REPORT OF THE MSM AND TGW SURVEY 2024**

Jamaica has both a generalized and a concentrated HIV epidemic, disproportionately affecting men who have sex with men (MSM) and transgender women (TGW). The adult HIV prevalence in Jamaica was 1.5% in 1996 (1), 1.6% in 2007 (2), 1.8% in 2017 (3) and 1.1% in 2023 (4) (UNAIDS 2024). The number of persons living with HIV has declined from an estimated 32,627 in 2018 (5) to 26,000 (13,000 men and 13,000 women) in 2023 (4). HIV related deaths have declined by 32% since 2010 (4) due to expansion of the anti-retroviral treatment program. An estimated 1,200 adults and children were newly infected with HIV in 2023, representing a 10% decline since 2010 (4). Most persons newly HIV infected in 2023 are adult men, many of whom are men who have sex with men (MSM) (4).

Historically the HIV prevalence among MSM in Jamaica has been high. When the first survey was conducted among MSM in Jamaica in 1986 the HIV prevalence was 9.6% (6). By 1995 the HIV prevalence among MSM was as high as 32.3% and it remained high at 32.9% in 2007 (7), 31.4% in 2011 (8) and 32.9% in 2017 (9). The 876 study in 2017 was the first to make a distinction between MSM and transgender women (TGW) while earlier studies had included TGW as MSM. The HIV prevalence among TGW in 2017 was 51.0%, considerably higher than that found in MSM (29.6%), or in both MSM and TGW combined (32.9%) (9). In Jamaica, same-sex intimacy and transgender and gender diverse people remain stigmatized, and the Offences Against the Person Act criminalizes anal sex, further perpetuating discrimination against MSM and TGW populations. Despite numerous educational campaigns from the outset of the HIV epidemic, homosexuality and HIV continue to be highly stigmatized in Jamaica although somewhat less than previously (5,7,8,9).

These findings highlight the ongoing challenges in addressing HIV in Jamaica and underscore the need for targeted interventions to reduce stigma and improve access to prevention and care for MSM and TGW.

**TABLE 1 HIV PREVALENCE AMONG MSM IN JAMAICA**

| <b>Year</b> | <b>No. of MSM surveyed</b>         | <b>HIV prevalence</b>                           | <b>Reference</b>                                     |
|-------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| 1986        | 125                                | 9.6%                                            | Murphy, Gibbs, Figueroa et al. JAIDS 1988 (6)        |
| 1995        | 201                                | 32.3%                                           | Rossi unpublished and not available                  |
| 2007        | 207                                | 32.9%                                           | Figueroa, Weir, Jones-Cooper et al. WIMJ 2012 (7)    |
| 2011        | 449                                | 31.4%                                           | Figueroa, Jones Cooper, Edwards et al. PLOS 2015 (8) |
| 2017        | 652<br>537 MSM,<br>102 TGW, 13 TGM | 32.9% (MSM & TGW)<br>29.6% (MSM)<br>51.0% (TGW) | 876 study MOHW report 2018 unpublished (9)           |

Although five surveys have already been conducted among MSM, the prevention response still needs strategic information to improve programs and find ways of reducing HIV infection among MSM and TGW. This includes information to monitor the prevalence of HIV and other STI, associated risk factors and behaviours as well as access to care and support. However, new creative thinking and action will also be needed as well as stronger advocacy for policy and structural changes in society and social norms.

### ***OBJECTIVES OF MSM AND TGW SURVEY 2024***

Given this context, the Ministry of Health and Wellness has commissioned a MSM and TGW survey 2024 with the following objectives:

1. Determine the prevalence of HIV and Syphilis among the MSM and TGW populations in Jamaica.
2. Assess the risk behaviours among MSM and TGW.
3. Assess engagement along the continuum of HIV prevention and care among MSM and TGW.
4. Determine effectiveness of prevention interventions among MSM and TGW.
5. Estimate the population size of MSM and TGW populations.
6. Assess the psychosocial needs of MSM and TGW.
7. Strengthen syphilis reporting, referral and linkage to treatment services.
8. Measure proximate and underlying determinants of HIV transmission.
9. Understand the social and sexual networks of MSM and TGW populations.

There are significant benefits in conducting this survey:

### ***INDIVIDUAL BENEFITS TO PARTICIPANTS***

1. Testing & counselling – syphilis, HIV, viral load
2. Referral to treatment if positive for HIV and/or syphilis
3. Risk assessment
4. Assess psychosocial needs and comfort with self and services
5. Increase awareness of Pre-Exposure Prophylaxis (PrEP) and Post-Exposure Prophylaxis (PEP)
6. Assess access to condoms and lubrication
7. Assess prevention and treatment programs
8. Compensation for time & transportation (Phone card \$1000 + \$2,500)

## ***NATIONAL HIV/STI PROGRAM***

1. Enable Program to plan better
2. Provide data to transform attitudes towards acceptance and reduce Stigma & discrimination
3. Meet the needs of Global Fund and other donors to facilitate continued funding

## ***BENEFIT TO ALL***

4. Reduction in burden of HIV and Syphilis
5. Reduce social discord and conflict
6. Promote acceptance of diversity

In sum the aim is a better society with better services and a reduction in HIV incidence and prevalence among MSM and TGW and the entire population. This will only be possible if we use the information gathered in a creative way to forge effective policies and programs to reduce HIV infection and promote healthy living.

## ***METHODS***

The implementation of this national survey of MSM and TGW in 2024 was guided by previously developed protocols and MSM surveys in Jamaica. The protocols include a quantitative HIV prevalence and behavioural survey consistent with the UNAIDS/WHO BBS-lite (Bio-Behavioural survey “lite”) method (10) which features three (3) strategies for recruitment: 1) from people attending program sites; 2) at outreach locations; and 3) peer referral from participants. In Jamaica, MSM and TGW were recruited through NGOs and MOHW program staff that had longstanding relations with these populations providing HIV prevention, treatment, care and support services for them as well as by peer referral and targeted outreach.

The study was implemented at all known program sites in Jamaica, (dubbed “facility locations” in this report) providing targeted prevention services to MSM or TGW during the study period. Recruitment of participants was sequential at each facility location to reduce bias from interviewer preference. Treatment sites were excluded. Recruitment was also conducted during all known outreach efforts during the study period. All MSM and TGW participating in an outreach activity such as a workshop were invited to participate in the study. Refusals were monitored. Participants recruited at facility or outreach locations were offered appointment cards and invitation letters to invite their peers. Recruitment clusters

were identified by parish, month and type: facility-based, outreach, or referral (e.g. a cluster could be recruitment at JASL facility in KSA during August).

Respondents had to be born a male, aged 18 years or older, or 16 -17 years and not be with parents or on a family errand, and must have had anal sex with a man in the past year. They could not have previously participated in the current survey. A TGW is a person who was born with male biologic sex who identifies as female gender. Additionally, in this study, persons who described themselves as “transgender” when asked to describe themselves were included as TGW even if they also self-identified as a man. All participants gave informed consent and agreed to answering a survey questionnaire and doing HIV and syphilis tests including having samples taken for viral load and TRUST antigen if positive for HIV and reactive for syphilis, respectively. Participants were assigned unique numbers. Names were not used on interviews, plasma separation cards or blood specimens. Names and contact information were collected and stored separately in a master log. The Ministry of Health and Wellness Ethics and Medico-Legal Advisory Panel approved the study and the informed consent process.

Experienced female interviewers were trained and used for conducting the survey including supervisors, and the study coordinator who was well known to the community. A structured questionnaire designed and uploaded on tablets was administered face-to-face, seeking information on socio-demographic status, HIV awareness, risk perception, sexual behaviour, condom use, STI symptoms, health seeking behaviour, drug use and social vulnerability. Participants had the option to self-complete a section on the questionnaire, considered to have sensitive questions, using the tablet used by the interviewer. The interviewer assessed socio-economic status using a scale of 1 (low) to 10 (high). Interviews took place privately at NGOs and mutually agreed sites including selected clinics and medical offices, workshop sites and in the interviewer’s car.

HIV testing was done using the Determine rapid test. Confirmation of HIV positive tests was done at the National Laboratory using an ELISA algorithm and PCR. If a participant tested positive on the Determine rapid test a dried blood sample was taken on plasma separation cards for viral load testing using Abbott PCR testing. Syphilis testing was done using Bioline with confirmation of positive results using *Treponema pallidum* particle agglutination assay (TPPA). A positive syphilis test was interpreted as “ever infected”. MSM with a positive TPPA and a TRUST titre of 8 or higher were considered to be currently infected. Confidential results were given to participants free of cost, with counselling and referral to treatment as indicated.

Interviews were conducted island wide from mid-July to early November 2024. The Epidemiology Research and Training Unit (ERTU) housed the study coordinator, supervisors and interviewers. The majority of interviews conducted using appointment cards were done at the ERTU. NGOs that facilitated the survey included Jamaica AIDS for Life (JASL), ASHE, Children First, Transwave, Equality for All Foundation and JN+. MOHW behaviour change communication (BCC) and outreach educators facilitated the survey through MSM workshops and contacting MSM to participate. In some instances, influential MSM and MSM peer

recruiters, including a party promoter, were used to reach MSM and the latter were compensated JM\$500 for each participant that they recruited who completed the survey.

We asked the organisations and staff facilitating recruitment to target recruitment of influential MSM first. Participants interviewed were offered 3 – 5 invitation letters and appointment cards to give to their peers to encourage them to do the survey. These cards were colour coded by Health Region and had a unique number so that network relations could be tracked. Participants who completed the survey were given a phone card of JM\$1000 and \$2500 cash as a contribution towards transport and their time. Participants were also given a card with the name and phone number of the study coordinator so they could contact her.

The survey began in the South-East Regional Health Authority (Kingston & St. Andrew) with the help of JASL and other NGOs, then went to the North-East Health Region, Western Region and the Southern Health Region. NGO and MOHW staff facilitated recruitment of most participants as part of their work without any additional pay. When they used their own phone to make calls, they were given phone cards as reimbursement for the cost. If they facilitated the study while interviews were taking place, snacks or lunch was provided. A few persons went well beyond the call of duty, and they were given modest honoraria. In addition, when required peer recruiters were paid \$500 for each MSM that they recruited who completed the survey. Five (5) peer recruiters were paid a total of \$40,000 for 80 participants recruited. The dual incentive system used in respondent-driven sampling (RDS) was not used (11). As noted, only 5 people were paid to recruit MSM. These recruiters were frequently relied on by the MOHW to recruit MSM for workshops.

The survey obtained data that can be used to assess the adequacy of current size estimates for MSM and TGW populations in Jamaica. All study protocols maintained confidentiality and considered the difficulties in identifying members of the MSM and TGW population and the concerns about unwanted exposure.

## **DATA ANALYSIS**

The study coordinator and the supervisors reviewed all questionnaires completed by interviewers as a quality control check prior to them being submitted to the database. Where indicated they would consult the interviewer to clarify any answers that appeared inconsistent. A further quality control review of the dataset was done by an experienced survey consultant (SW) prior to analysis.

Frequency distributions, cross-tabulations by HIV status for MSM and TGW was done, Prevalence odds ratios and 95% Confidence Intervals (CI) were prepared using SAS (SAS Inc. Cary, NC) adjusting for clustering of the sample. Clusters were identified by the organisation facilitating the recruitment, the approach taken (whether facility based or outreach/workshop) as well as the parish and month when recruitment took place.

## RESULTS

A total of 500 participants were recruited for the survey and completed interviews and blood tests. The majority of participants were recruited in Kingston and St Andrew (290) and St James (49) (Table 2).

**TABLE 2: RECRUITMENT BY HEALTH REGION AND PARISH**

| SERHA         |            | NERHA                     |           | WRHA                        |           | SRHA          |           |
|---------------|------------|---------------------------|-----------|-----------------------------|-----------|---------------|-----------|
| KSA           | 290        | St. Ann<br>(NGO 22 of 33) | 33        | Trelawny                    | 19        | Manchester    | 25        |
| St. Thomas    | 11         |                           |           | St. James<br>(NGO 21 of 49) | 49        | St. Elizabeth | 13        |
| St. Catherine | 23         |                           |           | Hanover                     | 17        | Clarendon     | 12        |
|               |            |                           |           | Westmoreland                | 8         |               |           |
| <b>Total</b>  | <b>324</b> |                           | <b>33</b> |                             | <b>93</b> |               | <b>50</b> |

Source: Tabulation by study coordinator

Only a few persons (6) turned away before being approached or refused to do the survey (4) while 17 persons were ineligible (Table 3). As many as 64 persons had already participated or attempted to participate in the survey twice. Study staff had to be alert to ensure that these persons did not do the survey more than once. Most participants were recruited through NGO service facilities and NGO and parish outreach and workshops while 11.1% of all participants were recruited by invitation cards given to them by a participant who was already interviewed.

**TABLE 3: RECRUITMENT OF PARTICIPANTS**

|                                                       | MSM | TGW | Total |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-----|-----|-------|
| Turned away before approached                         | 4   | 2   | 6     |
| Refusing to Participate                               |     |     | 4     |
| Ineligible                                            |     |     | 17    |
| Already Participated                                  |     |     | 40    |
| Attempted to participate twice                        |     |     | 24    |
| Recruitment by invitation cards                       | 53  | 3   | 56    |
| Recruitment by service facility, outreach or workshop | 406 | 38  | 444   |
| Total participants recruited                          | 459 | 41  | 500   |

Several NGOs facilitated the recruitment of participants in the survey including JASL, Ashe, Transwave and Children First (Table 4). Regional and Parish BCC staff and outreach officers also facilitated the recruitment of participants.

A total of 459 MSM and 41 TGW were recruited. 60.1% of MSM and 68.2% of TGW participants were aged 16 – 29 years. The majority of MSM (75.4%) and TGW (63.4%) were assessed by the interviewers to be truthful in their answers. Interviewers did doubt the responses to a few questions with 23.5% of MSM and 31.7% of TGW.

**TABLE 4: RECRUITMENT SOURCE AND PARISH AND AGE GROUP OF PARTICIPANTS**

|                                  | MSM |       | TG |       |
|----------------------------------|-----|-------|----|-------|
|                                  | n   | %     | n  | %     |
| <b>TOTAL</b>                     | 459 |       | 41 |       |
| <b>Recruitment Source</b>        |     |       |    |       |
| JASL                             | 139 | 30.3  | 12 | 29.3  |
| Ashe                             | 52  | 11.3  | 2  | 4.9   |
| Ashe Outreach Mobile             | 11  | 2.4   | 0  | 0.0   |
| Transwave                        | 7   | 1.5   | 8  | 19.5  |
| Children First Outreach Workshop | 5   | 1.1   | 4  | 9.8   |
| BCC Outreach Workshops           | 81  | 17.7  | 5  | 12.2  |
| BCC Staff Other Outreach         | 56  | 12.2  | 2  | 4.9   |
| ERTU (Study Center)              | 72  | 15.7  | 7  | 17.1  |
| Paid Recruiters                  | 36  | 7.8   | 1  | 2.4   |
| <b>Parish of Recruitment</b>     |     |       |    |       |
| St Ann                           | 24  | 5.2   | 9  | 22.0  |
| Clarendon                        | 10  | 2.2   | 2  | 4.9   |
| Hanover                          | 14  | 3.1   | 1  | 2.4   |
| KSA                              | 269 | 58.6  | 24 | 58.5  |
| Manchester                       | 23  | 5.0   | 2  | 4.9   |
| St Catherine                     | 23  | 5.0   | 0  | 0.0   |
| St Elizabeth                     | 13  | 2.8   | 0  | 0.0   |
| St James                         | 49  | 10.7  | 0  | 0.0   |
| St Thomas                        | 8   | 1.7   | 0  | 0.0   |
| Trelawny                         | 17  | 3.7   | 2  | 4.9   |
| Westmoreland                     | 9   | 2.0   | 1  | 2.4   |
| <b>Age Group (years)</b>         |     |       |    |       |
| 16-19                            | 56  | 12.2  | 6  | 14.6  |
| 20-24                            | 113 | 24.6  | 11 | 26.8  |
| 25-29                            | 107 | 23.3  | 11 | 26.8  |
| 30-34                            | 74  | 16.1  | 8  | 19.5  |
| 35-39                            | 45  | 9.8   | 2  | 4.9   |
| 40-44                            | 23  | 5.0   | 3  | 7.3   |
| 45+                              | 41  | 8.9   | 0  | 0.0   |
| Green Coupon                     | 53  | 100.0 | 3  | 100.0 |
| <b>Interviewer Assessment</b>    |     |       |    |       |
| Truthful                         | 346 | 75.4  | 26 | 63.4  |
| Doubt a few of the responses     | 108 | 23.5  | 13 | 31.7  |
| Not Truthful                     | 5   | 1.1   | 2  | 4.9   |

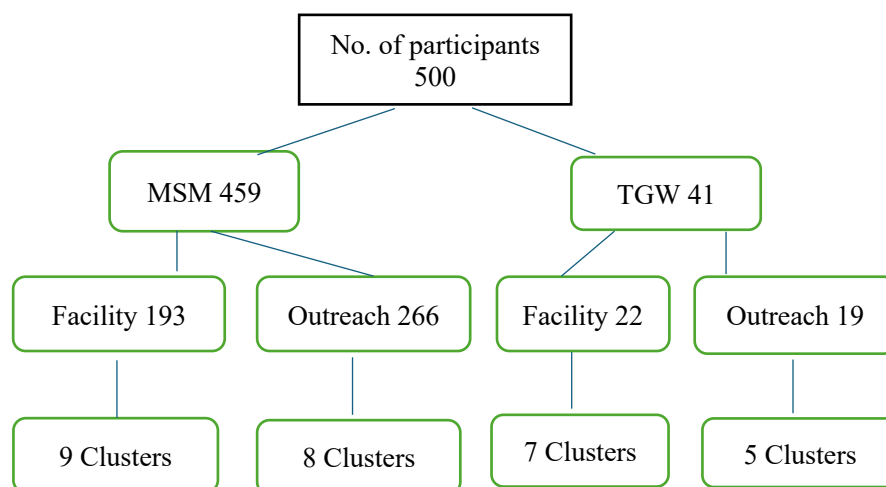
## RECRUITMENT APPROACH

The approach to recruiting participants was consistent with the UNAIDS/WHO Bio-Behavioural Survey (BBS-Lite) method. This method includes three approaches:

1. Consecutive recruitment of eligible persons attending HIV service programs organised by NGOs or government health facilities.
2. Outreach activities aimed at reaching MSM and TGW including HIV education and skill building workshops.
3. Recruitment by snowballing using invitation letters and appointment cards offered to participants on completion of their interview. Participants were asked to share these with their peers to encourage them to do the survey. The appointment card has the first name and phone number of the study coordinator so prospective participants can phone her and make an appointment to be interviewed. No financial incentive was provided to participants who helped to enrol new participants by this method.

All three approaches were used in this survey to good effect.

**FIGURE 1: RECRUITMENT FLOW DIAGRAM USING BBS-LITE APPROACH**



A total of 459 MSM were recruited, 193 (42.0%) through services at NGO facilities and 266 (58.0%) through outreach and workshop activities of NGOs and parish health staff (Figure 1). 41 transgender women were recruited.

Participants were assigned to clusters based on the source of their recruitment (service at an NGO facility or outreach and workshop) as well as the parish where they were recruited and the month when recruited. Participants presenting appointment cards were assigned to the same cluster as the participant who gave them their appointment card or who told them about the survey.

Approximately half of all participants 48.4% (MSM 47.9%, TGW 53.6%) were aged 20-29 years while 12% were 16-19 years (Table 5). 8.9% of MSM were 45 years or older while there were no TGW in the sample over the age of 45 years.

**TABLE 5: DISTRIBUTION OF MSM BY RECRUITMENT APPROACH & AGE GROUP AND TGW BY AGE GROUP**

| Age group (years) | MSM by recruitment approach |      |          |      |       |      | Transgender women |      | All participants |      |
|-------------------|-----------------------------|------|----------|------|-------|------|-------------------|------|------------------|------|
|                   | Facility                    |      | Outreach |      | Total |      |                   |      |                  |      |
|                   | N                           | %    | N        | %    | N     | %    | N                 | %    | N                | %    |
| 16-19             | 23                          | 11.9 | 33       | 12.4 | 56    | 12.2 | 6                 | 14.6 | 62               | 12.4 |
| 20-24             | 48                          | 24.9 | 65       | 24.4 | 113   | 24.6 | 11                | 26.8 | 124              | 24.8 |
| 25-29             | 48                          | 24.9 | 59       | 22.2 | 107   | 23.3 | 11                | 26.8 | 118              | 23.6 |
| 30-34             | 40                          | 20.7 | 34       | 12.8 | 74    | 16.1 | 8                 | 19.5 | 82               | 16.4 |
| 35-39             | 20                          | 10.4 | 25       | 9.4  | 45    | 9.8  | 2                 | 4.9  | 47               | 9.4  |
| 40-44             | 5                           | 2.6  | 18       | 6.8  | 23    | 5.0  | 3                 | 7.3  | 26               | 5.2  |
| 45-49             | 1                           | 0.5  | 12       | 4.5  | 13    | 2.8  | 0                 | 0    | 13               | 2.6  |
| 50-65             | 8                           | 4.2  | 20       | 7.5  | 28    | 6.1  | 0                 | 0    | 28               | 5.6  |
| Total             | 193                         | 100% | 266      | 100% | 459   | 100% | 41                | 100% | 500              | 100% |

Participants living in all fourteen (14) parishes participated in the survey. Most (69.2%) participants said that they lived in Kingston and St. Andrew, St. Catherine and St. James. There were only a few participants recruited who lived in Portland (0.2%), St. Mary (0.8%), Hanover (1.2%) and Trelawny (1.2%) (Table 6).

**TABLE 6: PARISH WHERE PARTICIPANTS LIVED**

| Parish                 | MSM by recruitment approach |      |          |      |       |      | Transgender women |      | All participants |      |
|------------------------|-----------------------------|------|----------|------|-------|------|-------------------|------|------------------|------|
|                        | Facility                    |      | Outreach |      | Total |      |                   |      |                  |      |
|                        | N                           | %    | N        | %    | N     | %    | N                 | %    | N                | %    |
| Kingston and St Andrew | 112                         | 58.0 | 66       | 24.8 | 178   | 38.8 | 18                | 43.9 | 196              | 39.2 |
| St Catherine           | 44                          | 22.8 | 45       | 16.9 | 89    | 19.4 | 7                 | 17.1 | 96               | 19.2 |
| St Thomas              | 4                           | 2.0  | 14       | 5.3  | 18    | 3.9  | 0                 | 0    | 18               | 3.6  |
| St. Mary               | 2                           | 1.0  | 1        | 0.4  | 3     | 0.7  | 1                 | 2.4  | 4                | 0.8  |
| St Ann                 | 12                          | 6.2  | 13       | 4.9  | 25    | 5.5  | 7                 | 17.1 | 32               | 6.4  |
| Portland               | 0                           | 0    | 1        | 0.4  | 1     | 0.2  | 0                 | 0    | 1                | 0.2  |
| Westmoreland           | 2                           | 1.0  | 26       | 9.8  | 28    | 6.1  | 3                 | 7.3  | 31               | 6.2  |
| Hanover                | 1                           | 0.5  | 4        | 1.5  | 5     | 1.1  | 1                 | 2.4  | 6                | 1.2  |
| St James               | 13                          | 6.7  | 41       | 15.4 | 54    | 11.8 | 0                 | 0    | 54               | 10.8 |
| Trelawny               | 0                           | 0    | 6        | 2.3  | 6     | 1.3  | 0                 | 0    | 6                | 1.2  |
| St Elizabeth           | 0                           | 0    | 15       | 5.6  | 15    | 3.3  | 0                 | 0    | 15               | 3.0  |
| Clarendon              | 1                           | 0.5  | 10       | 3.8  | 11    | 2.4  | 2                 | 4.9  | 13               | 2.6  |
| Manchester             | 2                           | 1.0  | 24       | 9.0  | 26    | 5.7  | 2                 | 4.9  | 28               | 5.6  |
| TOTAL                  | 193                         | 100% | 266      | 100% | 459   | 100% | 41                | 100% | 500              | 100% |

**EDUCATIONAL LEVEL**

Most participants (MSM 56.9%, TGW 53.7%) had completed high school. One third of MSM (33.8%) and one fifth of TGW (22.0%) had completed tertiary education (Table 7). Less than 2% of participants had not completed primary school while 4% had only primary education and 5% had only completed junior high or all age school. One fifth of participants were currently in school (MSM 23.1%, TGW 4.9%).

**TABLE 7: EDUCATION OF PARTICIPANTS (HIGHEST LEVEL COMPLETED IN SCHOOL)**

| Highest level completed in school | MSM by recruitment approach |      |          |      |       |      | Transgender women |      | All participants |      |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------|------|----------|------|-------|------|-------------------|------|------------------|------|
|                                   | Facility                    |      | Outreach |      | Total |      |                   |      |                  |      |
|                                   | N                           | %    | N        | %    | N     | %    | N                 | %    | N                | %    |
| Less Than Primary                 | 1                           | 0.5  | 5        | 1.9  | 6     | 1.3  | 1                 | 2.4  | 7                | 1.4  |
| Primary                           | 6                           | 3.1  | 9        | 3.4  | 15    | 3.3  | 6                 | 14.6 | 21               | 4.2  |
| Junior High / All Age             | 6                           | 3.1  | 16       | 6.0  | 22    | 4.8  | 3                 | 7.3  | 25               | 5    |
| High School/ Secondary            | 94                          | 48.7 | 167      | 62.8 | 261   | 56.9 | 22                | 53.7 | 283              | 56.6 |
| Tertiary (University)             | 86                          | 44.6 | 69       | 25.9 | 155   | 33.8 | 9                 | 22.0 | 164              | 32.8 |
| Currently in school               |                             |      |          |      |       |      |                   |      |                  |      |
| Yes                               | 56                          | 29.0 | 50       | 18.8 | 106   | 23.1 | 2                 | 4.9  | 108              | 21.6 |
| No                                | 137                         | 71.0 | 216      | 81.2 | 353   | 76.9 | 39                | 95.1 | 392              | 78.4 |

### Gender identity

Most MSM (96.3%) identified themselves as men and most TGW identified themselves as women (87.8%) (Table 8). Three (3) TGW self-identified as men but described themselves as transgender and were counted as TGW.

**TABLE 8: PARTICIPANTS BY GENDER AND UNION STATUS**

|                                                 | MSM by recruitment approach |      |          |      |       |      | Transgender women |      | All participants |      |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|------|----------|------|-------|------|-------------------|------|------------------|------|
|                                                 | Facility                    |      | Outreach |      | Total |      |                   |      |                  |      |
|                                                 | N                           | %    | N        | %    | N     | %    | N                 | %    | N                | %    |
| Is your gender man, woman or other?             |                             |      |          |      |       |      |                   |      |                  |      |
| Man                                             | 188                         | 97.4 | 254      | 95.5 | 442   | 96.3 | 3                 | 7.3  | 445              | 89   |
| Woman (TGW)                                     | 0                           | 0    | 0        | 0    | 0     | 0    | 36                | 87.8 | 36               | 7.2  |
| Other                                           | 5                           | 2.6  | 12       | 4.5  | 17    | 3.7  | 2                 | 4.9  | 19               | 3.8  |
| Married to or living with woman, man or neither |                             |      |          |      |       |      |                   |      |                  |      |
| Married/ living with a woman                    | 3                           | 1.6  | 26       | 9.8  | 29    | 6.3  | 0                 | 0    | 29               | 5.8  |
| Married or living with a man                    | 19                          | 9.8  | 35       | 13.2 | 54    | 11.8 | 10                | 24.4 | 64               | 12.8 |
| Neither                                         | 171                         | 88.6 | 205      | 77.1 | 376   | 81.9 | 31                | 75.6 | 407              | 81.4 |
| Do you have a main male sexual partner now?     |                             |      |          |      |       |      |                   |      |                  |      |
| Yes                                             | 98                          | 50.8 | 140      | 52.6 | 238   | 51.9 | 27                | 65.9 | 265              | 53.0 |
| No                                              | 95                          | 49.2 | 126      | 47.4 | 221   | 48.1 | 14                | 34.1 | 235              | 47.0 |

Nineteen (19) persons gave varied descriptions of their gender e.g. pansexual (8), non-binary (3), demi-sexual (2), queer (1), bicurious (1), fluid (1). Seventeen (17) of these participants met the study definition of MSM and two (2) were assessed to be TGW. Most MSM (81.9%) and TGW (75.6%) were neither married nor living with either a man or a woman. 6.3% of MSM were married to or living with a woman and 11.8% were married to or living with a man. 24.4% of TGW were married to or living with a man and none were married to or living with a woman.

### ***SOCIO-ECONOMIC STATUS***

The interviewer assessed the socio-economic status (SES) of participants on a scale of 1-10 with 1 being lowest and 10 being highest. 49% of participants were assessed as being SES 1-3, 48% as SES 4-6 and 3% SES 7-9 (Table 9). Most participants (61%) were assessed as being SES 3-4.

**TABLE 9: PARTICIPANTS BY SOCIO-ECONOMIC STATUS**

|     | MSM by recruitment approach |      |          |      |       |      | Transgender women |      | All participants |      |
|-----|-----------------------------|------|----------|------|-------|------|-------------------|------|------------------|------|
|     | Facility                    |      | Outreach |      | Total |      |                   |      |                  |      |
|     | N                           | %    | N        | %    | N     | %    | N                 | %    | N                | %    |
| 1   | 0                           | 0    | 2        | 0.8  | 2     | 0.4  | 0                 | 0    | 2                | 0.4  |
| 2   | 20                          | 10.4 | 34       | 12.8 | 54    | 11.8 | 10                | 24.4 | 64               | 12.8 |
| 3   | 51                          | 26.4 | 111      | 41.7 | 162   | 35.3 | 18                | 43,9 | 180              | 36.0 |
| 4   | 47                          | 24.4 | 68       | 25,6 | 115   | 35.1 | 11                | 26.8 | 126              | 25.2 |
| 5   | 38                          | 19.7 | 38       | 14.3 | 76    | 16.6 | 1                 | 2.4  | 77               | 15.4 |
| 6   | 24                          | 12.4 | 13       | 4.9  | 37    | 8.1  | 1                 | 2.4  | 38               | 7.6  |
| 7   | 8                           | 4.2  | 0        | 0    | 8     | 1.7  | 0                 | 0    | 8                | 1.6  |
| 8   | 3                           | 1.6  | 0        | 0    | 3     | 0.7  | 0                 | 0    | 3                | 0.6  |
| 9   | 2                           | 1.0  | 0        | 0    | 2     | 0.4  | 0                 | 0    | 2                | 0.4  |
| All | 193                         | 100% | 266      | 100% | 459   | 100% | 41                | 100% | 500              | 100% |

## **HIV PREVALENCE**

HIV prevalence among MSM participants was 27.0% (95% CI 22.9%-31.3%) (Table 10). HIV prevalence was higher among MSM recruited through outreach activities (32.0%, 95% CI 26.3%-37.6%) than those recruited at NGO facilities (20.7%, 95% CI 15.0%-26.5%). Note that the study did not recruit from facility settings when ART was being provided.

**TABLE 10: HIV PREVALENCE AMONG MSM BY RECRUITMENT LOCATION**

| Stratum           |       | MSM |       | 95% Confidence Limits |      |
|-------------------|-------|-----|-------|-----------------------|------|
|                   |       | N   | %     | %                     | %    |
| Facility Location | HIV+  | 40  | 20.7  | 15.0                  | 26.5 |
|                   | HIV-  | 153 | 79.3  | 73.5                  | 85.0 |
|                   | Total | 193 | 100   |                       |      |
| Outreach Location | HIV+  | 84  | 32.0  | 26.3                  | 37.6 |
|                   | HIV-  | 182 | 68.4  | 62.4                  | 73.7 |
|                   | Total | 266 | 100   |                       |      |
| Total             | HIV+  | 124 | 27.0  | 22.9                  | 31.3 |
|                   | HIV-  | 334 | 73.0  | 68.7                  | 76.9 |
|                   | Total | 459 | 100.0 |                       |      |

HIV prevalence among MSM increased significantly from 10.7% (95% CI 3.0%-18.4%) among teens, to 14.2% (95% CI 7.2%-21.1%) among age group 20-24 years to 29.0% (95% CI 21.5%-36.4%) among those 25-29 years to over 40% among MSM 35 years or older (Table 11).

**TABLE 11: HIV PREVALENCE OF MSM BY AGE GROUP**

| MSM       |            |     | 95% Confidence Limits |      |      |
|-----------|------------|-----|-----------------------|------|------|
| Age group | HIV status | N   | %                     | %    | %    |
| 16-19     | HIV+       | 6   | 10.7                  | 3.0  | 18.4 |
|           | HIV-       | 50  | 89.3                  | 81.6 | 97.0 |
|           | Total      | 56  | 100                   |      |      |
| 20-24     | HIV+       | 16  | 14.2                  | 7.2  | 21.1 |
|           | HIV-       | 97  | 85.8                  | 78.9 | 92.8 |
|           | Total      | 113 | 100                   |      |      |
| 25-29     | HIV+       | 31  | 29.0                  | 21.5 | 36.4 |
|           | HIV-       | 76  | 71.0                  | 63.6 | 78.5 |
|           | Total      | 107 | 100                   |      |      |
| 30-34     | HIV+       | 24  | 32.4                  | 22.2 | 42.6 |
|           | HIV-       | 50  | 67.6                  | 57.4 | 77.8 |
|           | Total      | 74  | 100                   |      |      |
| 35-39     | HIV+       | 20  | 44.4                  | 31.3 | 62.0 |
|           | HIV-       | 25  | 55.6                  | 38.0 | 68.7 |
|           | Total      | 45  | 100                   |      |      |
| 40-44     | HIV+       | 10  | 43.5                  | 19.7 | 67.3 |
|           | HIV-       | 13  | 56.5                  | 32.7 | 80.3 |
|           | Total      | 23  | 100                   |      |      |
| 45-00     | HIV+       | 17  | 41.5                  | 20.2 | 62.7 |
|           | HIV-       | 24  | 58.5                  | 37.3 | 79.8 |
|           | Total      | 41  | 100                   |      |      |
| Total     | HIV+       | 124 | 27.0                  | 22.9 | 31.6 |
|           | HIV-       | 335 | 73.0                  | 68.4 | 77.1 |
|           | Total      | 459 | 100%                  |      |      |

HIV prevalence among TGW was 53.7% (95% CI 37.7%-69.6%), significantly higher than among MSM 27.0% (95% CI 22.9%-31.3%) (Table12). HIV prevalence was higher among TGW recruited at facilities (63.6%, 95% CI 42.7%-84.6%) than TGW recruited through outreach activities (42.1%, 95% CI 18.9%-65.3%).

**TABLE 12: HIV PREVALENCE AMONG TRANSGENDER WOMEN BY RECRUITMENT LOCATION**

| Stratum           |       | 95% Confidence Limits |      |      |      |
|-------------------|-------|-----------------------|------|------|------|
|                   |       | N                     | %    | %    | %    |
| Facility Location | HIV+  | 14                    | 63.6 | 42.7 | 84.6 |
|                   | HIV-  | 8                     | 36.4 | 15.4 | 57.3 |
|                   | Total | 22                    | 100  |      |      |
| Outreach Location | HIV+  | 8                     | 42.1 | 18.9 | 65.3 |
|                   | HIV-  | 11                    | 57.9 | 34.7 | 81.1 |
|                   | Total | 19                    | 100  |      |      |
| Total             | HIV+  | 22                    | 53.7 | 37.7 | 69.6 |
|                   | HIV-  | 19                    | 46.3 | 30.4 | 62.3 |
|                   | Total | 41                    |      |      |      |

**SYPHILIS**

Prevalence of ever having syphilis among MSM was 29.2% (95% CI 21.3%-37.0%) (Table 13). Syphilis prevalence was significantly higher among MSM recruited by outreach activities (37.2%, 95% CI 29.0-45.4%) than those recruited at facilities 18.1%, 95% CI 9.0%-27.3%).

**TABLE 13: PREVALENCE OF SYPHILIS (PAST OR CURRENT) AMONG MSM BY RECRUITMENT LOCATION**

| Syphilis among MSM |              |                       |      |      |      |
|--------------------|--------------|-----------------------|------|------|------|
| Stratum            |              | 95% Confidence Limits |      |      |      |
|                    |              | N                     | %    | %    | %    |
| Facility location  | Reactive     | 35                    | 18.1 | 9.0  | 27.3 |
|                    | Non-Reactive | 158                   | 81.9 | 72.7 | 91.0 |
|                    | Total        | 193                   | 100  |      |      |
| Outreach location  | Reactive     | 99                    | 37.2 | 29.0 | 45.4 |
|                    | Non-Reactive | 167                   | 62.8 | 54.6 | 71.0 |
|                    | Total        | 266                   | 100  |      |      |
| Total              | Reactive     | 134                   | 29.2 | 21.3 | 37.0 |
|                    | Non-Reactive | 325                   | 70.8 | 63.0 | 78.7 |
|                    | Total        | 459                   |      |      |      |

Syphilis prevalence increased significantly among MSM by age from 10.7% (95% CI 0%-22%) among teens to 23.9% (95% CI 15.1%-32.7%) among age group 20-24 years, to 31.8% (95% CI 22.6%-41.0%) among age group 25-29 years and 42.2% (95% CI 24.2%-60.3%) among those aged 35-39 years (Table 14).

**TABLE 14: PREVALENCE OF SYPHILIS (PAST OR CURRENT) AMONG MSM BY AGE GROUP**

| Age group<br>(years) |              | MSM |      | 95% Confidence Limits |       |
|----------------------|--------------|-----|------|-----------------------|-------|
|                      |              | N   | %    | %                     | %     |
| <b>16-19</b>         | Reactive     | 6   | 10.7 | 0                     | 22.0  |
|                      | Non-Reactive | 50  | 89.3 | 78.0                  | 100.0 |
|                      | Total        | 56  | 100  |                       |       |
| <b>20-24</b>         | Reactive     | 27  | 23.9 | 15.1                  | 32.7  |
|                      | Non-Reactive | 86  | 76.1 | 67.3                  | 84.9  |
|                      | Total        | 113 | 100  |                       |       |
| <b>25-29</b>         | Reactive     | 34  | 31.8 | 22.6                  | 41.0  |
|                      | Non-Reactive | 73  | 68.2 | 59.0                  | 77.4  |
|                      | Total        | 107 | 100  |                       |       |
| <b>30-34</b>         | Reactive     | 25  | 33.8 | 21.4                  | 46.1  |
|                      | Non-Reactive | 49  | 66.2 | 53.9                  | 78.6  |
|                      | Total        | 74  | 100  |                       |       |
| <b>35-39</b>         | Reactive     | 19  | 42.2 | 24.2                  | 60.3  |
|                      | Non-Reactive | 26  | 57.8 | 39.7                  | 75.8  |
|                      | Total        | 45  | 100  |                       |       |
| <b>40-44</b>         | Reactive     | 7   | 30.4 | 11.5                  | 49.4  |
|                      | Non-Reactive | 16  | 69.6 | 50.6                  | 88.5  |
|                      | Total        | 23  | 100  |                       |       |
| <b>45+</b>           | Reactive     | 16  | 39.0 | 23.5                  | 54.5  |
|                      | Non-Reactive | 25  | 61.0 | 45.5                  | 76.5  |
|                      | Total        | 41  | 100  |                       |       |
| <b>Total</b>         | Reactive     | 134 | 29.2 | 22.1                  | 36.3  |
|                      | Non-Reactive | 325 | 70.8 | 63.7                  | 77.9  |
|                      | Total        | 459 | 100% |                       |       |

Prevalence of ever having syphilis among TGW was 51.2% (95% CI 35.2%-57.2%) (Table15). There was no significant difference in syphilis prevalence among TGW recruited at facilities or through outreach activities.

The number of study participants (MSM and TGW) with acute syphilis (defined as Bioline positive and TRUST antigen 1:8 or higher) was 47 (34.1%) of 138 of those ever having syphilis.

**TABLE 15: PREVALENCE OF SYPHILIS (PAST OR CURRENT) AMONG TRANSGENDER WOMEN**

| Stratum           |              | TG |      | 95% Confidence Limits |      |
|-------------------|--------------|----|------|-----------------------|------|
|                   |              | %  | %    | %                     | %    |
| Facility Location | Reactive     | 13 | 59.1 | 37.6                  | 80.5 |
|                   | Non-Reactive | 9  | 40.9 | 19.5                  | 62.4 |
|                   | Total        | 22 | 100  |                       |      |
| Outreach Location | Reactive     | 8  | 42.1 | 18.9                  | 65.3 |
|                   | Non-Reactive | 11 | 57.9 | 34.7                  | 81.1 |
|                   | Total        | 19 | 100  |                       |      |
| Total             | Reactive     | 21 | 51.2 | 35.2                  | 67.2 |
|                   | Non-Reactive | 20 | 48.8 | 32.8                  | 64.8 |
|                   | Total        | 41 | 100% |                       |      |

Nearly all participants (MSM 87.8%, TGW 97.6%) used the internet to socialize and meet new sex partners. Most participants went to parties and meet new sex partners (MSM 56.8%, TGW 78.1%) and many went on the street (MSM 51.9%, TGW 73.2%) as well as to bars and clubs (MSM 39.2%, TGW 51.2%).

### Money for Sex

Approximately one third (35.5%) of MSM and 61% of TGW had ever accepted money for sex while 18.5% of MSM and 48.8% of TGW had done so in the past 6 months (Table 16). More MSM and TGW admitted to accepting money for sex when answering the question privately on the tablet instead of face to face with the interviewer. Nearly one third of TGW (31.7%) and 16.3% of MSM reported having five or more one night stands in the past 12 months. A third of TGW (34.2%) and 29.0% of MSM believed that their main sex partner had sex with another person in the past 6 months. A third of MSM (30.3%) and 43.9% of TGW had sex before 16 years of age. Most MSM (91.5%) had never had sex with a TGW.

**TABLE 16: SEXUAL BEHAVIOUR OF MSM BY RECRUITMENT APPROACH AND TGW**

|                                                                                                    | MSM Facility |      | MSM Outreach |      | MSM all |      | TGW |      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|--------------|------|---------|------|-----|------|
|                                                                                                    | N            | %    | N            | %    | N       | %    | N   | %    |
| <b>Ever received money in exchange for sex</b>                                                     |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Yes                                                                                                | 56           | 29.0 | 107          | 40.2 | 163     | 35.5 | 25  | 61.0 |
| No                                                                                                 | 137          | 71.0 | 159          | 59.8 | 296     | 64.5 | 16  | 39.0 |
| <b>Received cash money from a person for sex in the past 6 months</b>                              |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Not applicable                                                                                     | 137          | 71.0 | 159          | 59.8 | 296     | 64.5 | 16  | 39.0 |
| Yes                                                                                                | 28           | 14.5 | 57           | 21.4 | 85      | 18.5 | 20  | 48.8 |
| No                                                                                                 | 28           | 14.5 | 50           | 18.8 | 78      | 17.0 | 5   | 12.2 |
| <b>Received cash money from a person for sex in the past 6 months (private response on tablet)</b> |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Yes                                                                                                | 30           | 15.5 | 66           | 24.8 | 96      | 20.9 | 22  | 53.7 |
| No                                                                                                 | 163          | 84.5 | 200          | 75.2 | 363     | 79.1 | 19  | 46.3 |
| <b>No. of one night stands in past 12 months</b>                                                   |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| 0                                                                                                  | 68           | 35.2 | 104          | 39.1 | 172     | 37.5 | 15  | 36.6 |
| 1                                                                                                  | 30           | 15.5 | 55           | 20.7 | 85      | 18.5 | 7   | 17.1 |
| 2                                                                                                  | 27           | 14.0 | 32           | 12.0 | 59      | 12.9 | 3   | 7.3  |
| 3                                                                                                  | 16           | 8.3  | 22           | 8.3  | 38      | 8.3  | 2   | 4.9  |
| 4                                                                                                  | 13           | 6.7  | 17           | 6.4  | 30      | 6.5  | 1   | 2.4  |
| 5+                                                                                                 | 39           | 20.2 | 36           | 13.5 | 75      | 16.3 | 13  | 31.7 |
| <b>Believe main male partner had sex with another person past 6 months</b>                         |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| No main partner                                                                                    | 95           | 49.2 | 126          | 47.4 | 221     | 48.2 | 14  | 34.2 |
| Yes                                                                                                | 57           | 29.5 | 76           | 28.6 | 133     | 29.0 | 14  | 34.2 |
| No                                                                                                 | 35           | 18.1 | 49           | 18.4 | 84      | 18.3 | 7   | 17.1 |
| Don't Know                                                                                         | 6            | 3.1  | 15           | 5.6  | 21      | 4.6  | 6   | 14.6 |
| <b>Age at first sex</b>                                                                            |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| <16                                                                                                | 50           | 25.9 | 89           | 33.5 | 139     | 30.3 | 18  | 43.9 |
| 16+                                                                                                | 143          | 74.1 | 177          | 66.5 | 320     | 69.7 | 23  | 56.1 |
| <b>Did you have sex with zero, 1, or &gt;1 transgender woman?</b>                                  |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Never had sex with a TGW                                                                           | 176          | 91.2 | 244          | 91.7 | 420     | 91.5 | 41  | 100  |
| One                                                                                                | 11           | 5.7  | 14           | 5.3  | 25      | 5.5  | 0   | 0    |
| More Than 1                                                                                        | 6            | 3.1  | 8            | 3.0  | 14      | 3.1  | 0   | 0    |

One third of MSM (34.6%) and 7.3% of TGW had sex with both men and women (Table 17). MSM recruited through outreach activities were much more likely to report sex with both men and women than those recruited at facilities (42.9% vs. 23.3%). As many as 58.6% of TGW and 31.9% of MSM had two or more male sex partners in the past 4 weeks. TGW had significantly more new male sex partners in the past 4 weeks than MSM (68.3% vs. 34.2%). 23.7% of MSM and 14.6% of TGW had one male sex partner in the past 12 months, while 16.3% of MSM and 14.6% of TGW had two sex partners in the past 12 months. 31.6% of MSM had 3-5 sex partners in the past 12 months and 28.2% had 6 or more sex partners. 31.7% of TGW had 3-5 sex partners in the past 12 months and 39.1% had 6 or more.

**TABLE 17: PROXIMATE DETERMINANTS OF INCREASED EXPOSURE TO HIV: MSM BY RECRUITMENT APPROACH AND TGW**

|                                                     | MSM Facility |      | MSM Outreach |       | MSM all |      | TGW |      |
|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|--------------|-------|---------|------|-----|------|
|                                                     | N            | %    | N            | %     | N       | %    | N   | %    |
| <b>Sex with only men or both men and women?</b>     |              |      |              |       |         |      |     |      |
| Only Men                                            | 148          | 76.7 | 152          | 57.1  | 300     | 65.4 | 38  | 92.7 |
| Both Men & Women                                    | 45           | 23.3 | 114          | 42.9  | 159     | 34.6 | 3   | 7.3  |
| <b>No. of men had sex with in past 4 weeks</b>      |              |      |              |       |         |      |     |      |
| 0                                                   | 41           | 21.2 | 56           | 21.1  | 97      | 21.1 | 4   | 9.8  |
| 1                                                   | 86           | 44.6 | 130          | 48.9  | 216     | 47.1 | 13  | 31.7 |
| 2-4                                                 | 53           | 27.5 | 63           | 23.7  | 116     | 25.3 | 14  | 34.2 |
| 5-9                                                 | 11           | 5.7  | 10           | 3.8   | 21      | 4.6  | 6   | 14.6 |
| 10+                                                 | 2            | 1.0  | 7            | 2.6   | 9       | 2.0  | 4   | 9.8  |
| <b>No. of new male sex partners in past 4 weeks</b> |              |      |              |       |         |      |     |      |
| No sex past 4 weeks                                 | 41           | 21.2 | 56           | 21.1  | 97      | 21.1 | 4   | 9.8  |
| 0                                                   | 77           | 39.9 | 128          | 48.1  | 205     | 44.7 | 9   | 22.0 |
| 1                                                   | 46           | 23.8 | 54           | 20.3  | 100     | 21.8 | 17  | 41.5 |
| 2+                                                  | 29           | 15.0 | 28           | 10.5  | 57      | 12.4 | 11  | 26.8 |
| <b>No. of male sex partners past 12 months</b>      |              |      |              |       |         |      |     |      |
| Missing                                             | 0            | 0.0  | 1            | 0.4   | 1       | 0.2  | 0   | 0    |
| 1                                                   | 37           | 19.2 | 72           | 27.1  | 109     | 23.7 | 6   | 14.6 |
| 2                                                   | 36           | 18.7 | 39           | 14.7  | 75      | 16.3 | 6   | 14.6 |
| 3-5                                                 | 60           | 31.1 | 85           | 32.0% | 145     | 31.6 | 13  | 31.7 |
| 6-10                                                | 35           | 18.1 | 41           | 15.4  | 76      | 16.6 | 4   | 9.8  |
| 11-20                                               | 18           | 9.3  | 21           | 7.9   | 39      | 8.5  | 7   | 17.1 |
| 21+                                                 | 7            | 3.6  | 7            | 2.6   | 14      | 3.1  | 5   | 12.2 |
| Total                                               | 193          | 100% | 266          | 100%  | 459     | 100% | 41  | 100% |

As many as 53% of MSM assessed that they had no or little risk of becoming HIV infected (Table 18). Far less TGW (26.8%) were of this view (Table 18). 19.2% of MSM and 31.7% of TGW reported that they were already HIV infected. 41.2% of MSM and 14.6% of TGW used a condom the last time they had sex with a woman. 38.3% of MSM and 73.2% of TGW had never had sex with a woman. 51.4% of MSM said that their partner used a condom the last time they had receptive anal intercourse. 24.0% of MSM said that they were never bottom. The majority of TGW (63.4%) said that their partner used a condom the last time they had sex with a man.

**TABLE 18: SELF-ASSESSMENT OF RISK OF HIV AND PROXIMATE DETERMINANTS OF TRANSMISSION GIVEN EXPOSURE**

|                                                                                           | MSM Facility |      | MSM Outreach |      | MSM all |      | TGW |      |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|--------------|------|---------|------|-----|------|
|                                                                                           | N            | %    | N            | %    | N       | %    | N   | %    |
| <b>To what extent do you think that you are at risk of becoming HIV infected?</b>         |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| No Chance Of Getting HIV                                                                  | 26           | 13.5 | 40           | 15.0 | 66      | 14.4 | 6   | 14.6 |
| Little Chance Of Getting HIV                                                              | 92           | 47.7 | 85           | 32.0 | 177     | 38.6 | 5   | 12.2 |
| Moderate chance of getting HIV                                                            | 32           | 16.6 | 47           | 17.7 | 79      | 17.2 | 9   | 22.0 |
| Good Chance Of Getting HIV                                                                | 15           | 7.8  | 34           | 12.8 | 49      | 10.7 | 8   | 19.5 |
| Already Infected                                                                          | 28           | 14.5 | 60           | 22.6 | 88      | 19.2 | 13  | 31.7 |
| <b>The last time you had sex with a woman, did you and your partner use a condom?</b>     |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Yes                                                                                       | 65           | 33.7 | 124          | 46.6 | 189     | 41.2 | 6   | 14.6 |
| No                                                                                        | 35           | 18.1 | 59           | 22.2 | 94      | 20.5 | 5   | 12.2 |
| Never Had Sex With A Woman                                                                | 93           | 48.2 | 83           | 31.2 | 176     | 38.3 | 30  | 73.2 |
| <b>The last time you had anal sex and you were bottom, did your partner use a condom?</b> |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Yes                                                                                       | 89           | 46.1 | 147          | 55.3 | 236     | 51.4 | 26  | 63.4 |
| No                                                                                        | 58           | 30.1 | 55           | 20.7 | 113     | 24.6 | 15  | 36.6 |
| Never Bottom                                                                              | 46           | 23.8 | 64           | 24.1 | 110     | 24.0 | 0   | 0.0  |
| <b>Syphilis result</b>                                                                    |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Reactive                                                                                  | 35           | 18.1 | 99           | 37.2 | 134     | 29.2 | 21  | 51.2 |
| Non-Reactive                                                                              | 158          | 81.9 | 167          | 62.8 | 325     | 70.8 | 20  | 48.8 |

25.5% of MSM and 14.6% of TGW said that they had ever taken pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP) (Table 19). 6.3% of MSM and none of the TGW said that they were married or living with a woman while 11.8% of MSM and 24.4% of TGW said that they were married or living with a man. One third of MSM (34.6%) and 7.3% of TGW said that they had sex with both men and women.

**TABLE 19: SELECTED PROTECTIVE PROXIMATE DETERMINANTS OF MSM/TGW SURVEY PARTICIPANTS**

|                                                 | MSM Facility |      | MSM Outreach |      | MSM all |      | TGW |      |
|-------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|--------------|------|---------|------|-----|------|
|                                                 | N            | %    | N            | %    | N       | %    | N   | %    |
| <b>Have you ever taken PrEP?</b>                |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Yes                                             | 82           | 42.5 | 35           | 13.2 | 117     | 25.5 | 6   | 14.6 |
| No                                              | 111          | 57.5 | 230          | 86.5 | 341     | 74.3 | 35  | 85.4 |
| Does Not Know                                   | 0            | 0.0  | 1            | 0.4  | 1       | 0.2  | 0   | 0.0  |
| <b>Sex with only men or both men and women?</b> |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Only Men                                        | 148          | 76.7 | 152          | 57.1 | 300     | 65.4 | 38  | 92.7 |
| Both men & women                                | 45           | 23.3 | 114          | 42.9 | 159     | 34.6 | 3   | 7.3  |
| <b>Married to or living with</b>                |              |      |              |      |         |      |     |      |
| Married or living with a woman                  | 3            | 1.6  | 26           | 9.8  | 29      | 6.3  | 0   | 0.0  |
| Married or living with a man                    | 19           | 9.8  | 35           | 13.2 | 54      | 11.8 | 10  | 24.4 |
| Neither                                         | 171          | 88.6 | 205          | 77.1 | 376     | 81.9 | 31  | 75.6 |

## **PRE-EXPOSURE PROPHYLAXIS (PREP)**

Most participants (MSM 87.0%, TGW 92.7%) had heard about PrEP and the majority (MSM 67.3%, TGW 59.4%) were interested in learning more about whether PrEP could help them. Many MSM (31.0%) and TGW (37.5%) were not interested in learning more about PrEP. Reasons given for not taking PrEP included: did not know enough about it, not eligible, don't feel at risk of HIV, did not know where to get it, afraid of side effects and don't want it. Among participants who had ever taken PrEP, 12.0% of MSM and 16.7% of TGW were HIV positive compared with 32.0% of MSM and 60.0% TGW who had never taken PrEP (Table 20). 88 MSM and 5 TGW said that they took PrEP in the past 6 months while 53 MSM and 4 TGW said that within the past 6 months they had stopped taking PrEP. The main reasons for stopping PrEP were "felt it was no longer necessary" and "had side effects".

**TABLE 20: SELECTED PROTECTIVE PROXIMATE DETERMINANTS BY HIV STATUS AND PREVALENCE**

|                                           | MSM  |      |       |       | TGW  |      |       |       |
|-------------------------------------------|------|------|-------|-------|------|------|-------|-------|
|                                           | HIV+ | HIV- | Total | % +ve | HIV+ | HIV- | Total | % +ve |
| Have you ever taken prep?"                |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                       | 14   | 103  | 117   | 12.0  | 1    | 5    | 6     | 16.7  |
| No                                        | 109  | 232  | 341   | 32.0  | 21   | 14   | 35    | 60.0  |
| Does Not Know                             |      |      | 1     |       |      |      |       |       |
| Sex with only men or both men and women?" |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Only Men                                  | 90   | 210  | 300   | 30.0  | 20   | 18   | 38    | 52.6  |
| Both men & women                          | 34   | 125  | 159   | 21.4  | 2    | 1    | 3     | 66.7  |
| Married to or living with                 |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Married or living with a woman            | 4    | 25   | 29    | 13.8  |      |      | 0     |       |
| Married or living with a man              | 21   | 33   | 54    | 38.9  | 6    | 4    | 10    | 60.0  |
| Neither                                   | 99   | 277  | 376   | 26.3  | 16   | 15   | 31    | 51.6  |
| Age at first sex with a man               |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| < 16 years                                | 49   | 90   | 139   | 35.3  | 9    | 9    | 18    | 50.0  |
| 16 + years                                | 75   | 245  | 320   | 23.4  | 13   | 10   | 23    | 56.5  |

MSM who were married to or living with a woman were less likely to be HIV positive than MSM who were married to or living with a man (13.8% vs. 38.9%). MSM who were aged 16 years of age or older at first sex were less likely to be HIV positive (23.4% vs 35.3%). HIV prevalence was lower among MSM who had sex with both women and men (21.4%, 95% CI 14.0% - 28.8%) than among MSM who had sex only with men (30.0%, 95% CI 22.1% - 37.3%), however this was not statistically significant, prevalence ratio 0.9, 95% CI 0.76 – 1.04.

## **ADVERSE LIFE EVENTS**

Many MSM and TGW were abused as a child or suffered one or more adverse life events (Table 21). Prevalence of these adverse events were higher among TGW than MSM. As a child, 54.5% of MSM and 68.3% of TGW were beaten, 47.9% of MSM and 63.4% of TGW were

verbally abused or neglected, 28.4% of MSM and 46.3% of TGW were sexually abused and 43.5% of MSM and 55.0% of TGW witnessed their mother or someone else verbally or physically abused. One quarter of MSM (25.8%) and 53.7% of TGW had been raped and 27.7% of MSM and 61.0% of TGW had been violently attacked by a sexual partner. 28.8% of MSM and 73.2% of TGW had slept outdoors or in a shelter because they were homeless while 9.4% of MSM and 24.4% of TGW had never completed high school.

**TABLE 21: ADVERSE LIFE EVENTS BY RECRUITMENT OF MSM AND BY TGW**

|                                                                            | MSM Facility |      | MSM Outreach |      | MSM all |      | TGW all |      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|--------------|------|---------|------|---------|------|
|                                                                            | N            | %    | N            | %    | N       | %    | N       | %    |
| <b>Highest level of school completed</b>                                   |              |      |              |      |         |      |         |      |
| < Primary, primary, All Age                                                | 13           | 6.7  | 30           | 11.3 | 43      | 9.4  | 10      | 24.4 |
| High school or tertiary                                                    | 180          | 93.3 | 236          | 88.7 | 416     | 90.6 | 31      | 75.6 |
| <b>Ever raped</b>                                                          |              |      |              |      |         |      |         |      |
| Yes                                                                        | 47           | 24.3 | 71           | 26.9 | 118     | 25.8 | 22      | 53.7 |
| No                                                                         | 146          | 75.7 | 193          | 73.1 | 339     | 74.2 | 19      | 46.3 |
| <b>Ever slept outdoors or in a shelter because homeless?</b>               |              |      |              |      |         |      |         |      |
| Yes                                                                        | 38           | 19.7 | 94           | 35.3 | 132     | 28.8 | 30      | 73.2 |
| No                                                                         | 155          | 80.3 | 172          | 64.7 | 327     | 71.2 | 11      | 26.8 |
| <b>Verbally abused or neglected as a child</b>                             |              |      |              |      |         |      |         |      |
| Yes                                                                        | 94           | 48.7 | 126          | 47.4 | 220     | 47.9 | 26      | 63.4 |
| No                                                                         | 99           | 51.3 | 140          | 42.6 | 239     | 42.1 | 15      | 36.6 |
| <b>Hit or beaten as a child</b>                                            |              |      |              |      |         |      |         |      |
| Yes                                                                        | 102          | 52.8 | 148          | 55.6 | 250     | 54.5 | 28      | 68.3 |
| No                                                                         | 91           | 47.2 | 118          | 44.4 | 209     | 45.5 | 13      | 31.7 |
| <b>Sexually abused as a child</b>                                          |              |      |              |      |         |      |         |      |
| Yes                                                                        | 56           | 29.0 | 74           | 28.0 | 130     | 28.4 | 19      | 46.3 |
| No                                                                         | 137          | 71.0 | 190          | 72.0 | 327     | 71.6 | 22      | 53.7 |
| <b>Ever violently attacked by a sexual partner</b>                         |              |      |              |      |         |      |         |      |
| Yes                                                                        | 48           | 24.9 | 79           | 29.7 | 127     | 27.7 | 25      | 61.0 |
| No                                                                         | 145          | 75.1 | 187          | 70.3 | 332     | 72.3 | 16      | 39.0 |
| <b>As a child was your mother or anyone verbally or physically abused?</b> |              |      |              |      |         |      |         |      |
| Yes                                                                        | 82           | 42.5 | 117          | 44.3 | 199     | 43.5 | 22      | 55.0 |
| No                                                                         | 111          | 47.5 | 147          | 55.7 | 258     | 46.5 | 18      | 45.0 |

HIV prevalence was higher among MSM who had ever been raped (38.1%), slept outdoors or in a shelter (37.9%), been sexually abused as a child (33.8%) or violently attacked by their sexual partner (36.2%) as well of MSM who had not completed high school (51.2%) (Table 22). HIV prevalence was uniformly higher for these adverse life events among TGW than MSM. However, the sample size for TGW was small and the confidence intervals would therefore be wide. Among MSM HIV prevalence was significantly associated with ever been raped (38.1% vs. 22.7%, adjusted prevalence ratio 1.7 95% CI 1.2 – 2.3).

**TABLE 22: EDUCATIONAL LEVEL AND ADVERSE LIFE EVENTS FOR MSM AND TGW IN JAMAICA 2024**

|                                                                            | MSM  |      |       |       | TGW  |      |       |       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|------|-------|-------|------|------|-------|-------|
|                                                                            | HIV+ | HIV- | Total | % +ve | HIV+ | HIV- | Total | % +ve |
| <b>Highest level of school completed</b>                                   |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| < Primary, primary, All Age                                                | 22   | 21   | 43    | 51.2  | 6    | 4    | 10    | 60.0  |
| High school or tertiary                                                    | 102  | 314  | 416   | 24.5  | 16   | 15   | 31    | 51.6  |
| <b>Ever raped</b>                                                          |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                                        | 45   | 73   | 118   | 38.1  | 11   | 11   | 22    | 50.0  |
| No                                                                         | 77   | 262  | 339   | 22.7  | 11   | 8    | 19    | 57.9  |
| <b>Ever slept outdoors or in a shelter because homeless?</b>               |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                                        | 50   | 82   | 132   | 37.9  | 16   | 14   | 30    | 53.3  |
| No                                                                         | 74   | 253  | 327   | 22.6  | 6    | 5    | 11    | 54.5  |
| <b>Verbally abused or neglected as a child</b>                             |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                                        | 61   | 159  | 220   | 27.7  | 12   | 14   | 26    | 46.2  |
| No                                                                         | 63   | 176  | 239   | 26.3  | 10   | 5    | 15    | 56.7  |
| <b>Hit or beaten as a child</b>                                            |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                                        | 69   | 181  | 250   | 27.6  | 14   | 14   | 28    | 50.0  |
| No                                                                         | 55   | 154  | 209   | 26.3  | 8    | 5    | 13    | 61.5  |
| <b>Sexually abused as a child</b>                                          |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                                        | 44   | 86   | 130   | 33.8  | 10   | 9    | 19    | 52.6  |
| No                                                                         | 79   | 248  | 327   | 24.2  | 12   | 10   | 22    | 54.5  |
| <b>Ever violently attacked by a sexual partner</b>                         |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                                        | 46   | 81   | 127   | 36.2  | 14   | 11   | 25    | 56.0  |
| No                                                                         | 78   | 254  | 332   | 23.5  | 8    | 8    | 16    | 50.0  |
| <b>As a child was your mother or anyone verbally or physically abused?</b> |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                                        | 47   | 152  | 199   | 23.6  | 12   | 10   | 22    | 54.5  |
| No                                                                         | 76   | 181  | 257   | 29.6  | 9    | 9    | 18    | 50.0  |

## CONDOM USE

51.9% of MSM and 65.9% of TGW reported having a main male sex partner. 58.8% of MSM and 48.2% of TGW said that they used a condom the last time that they had sex with their main male sex partner. A majority of MSM (55.9%) and TGW (51.9%) said that they believed their main male partner had sex with another person in the past 6 months. 17.4% of MSM and none of the TGW said that they had a main female sex partner. Among the MSM with a main female partner, 72.5% said that they used a condom the last time they had sex with her. Most participants (MSM 77.3%, TGW 73.2%) said that they had a new sex partner in the past 12 months. Nearly all participants (MSM 95.4%, TGW 97.6%) said it was very easy or easy to get a condom. 25.5% of MSM and 19.5% of TGW said that they had a condom with them at the interview. Amongst those saying that they had a condom with them 74.4% of MSM and 87.5% of TGW were able to show the condom. More than one third of the participants (MSM

35.8%, TGW 39.0%) said that they used a condom every time they had sex the last 10 times. 29.8% of MSM and 24.4% of TGW said that they used a condom 6 to 9 times the last 10 times they had sex while 26.8% of MSM and 21.9% of TGW said they used a condom 1 to 5 times the last 10 times they had sex. A quarter of participants (MSM 25.5%, TGW 26.8%) said that they were circumcised.

### ***MONEY for SEX and HIV PREVALENCE***

Payment for sex was the main source of income for 3.5% of MSM and 31.7% of TGW although 35.5% of MSM (n = 163) and 61.0% of TGW (n = 25) reported ever receiving money in exchange for sex (Table 23). Among those reporting ever receiving money for sex, 52.6% of MSM (n = 85) and 80.0% of TGW (n = 20) said that they had received cash for sex in the past 6 months. When asked whether a condom was used the last time they received money for sex, 84.7% of MSM and 72.0% of TGW who ever received cash for sex, said yes. HIV prevalence among participants ever receiving money for sex was 38.0% for MSM and 52.0% for TGW compared with persons never receiving money for sex (MSM 21.3%, TGW 69.2%). 18.1% of MSM and 19.5% of TGW reported that they had ever paid money for sex.

**TABLE 23: MONEY IN EXCHANGE FOR SEX AMONG MSM AND TGW IN JAMAICA 2024**

|                                                             | MSM  |      |       |       | TGW  |      |       |       |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|------|------|-------|-------|------|------|-------|-------|
|                                                             | HIV+ | HIV- | Total | % +ve | HIV+ | HIV- | Total | % +ve |
| <b>Ever received money for sex</b>                          |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                         | 62   | 101  | 163   | 38.0  | 13   | 12   | 25    | 52.0  |
| No                                                          | 62   | 234  | 296   | 20.9  | 9    | 7    | 16    | 69.2  |
| <b>Money for sex in past 6 months</b>                       |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                         | 32   | 53   | 85    | 37.6  | 11   | 9    | 20    | 55.0  |
| No                                                          | 30   | 48   | 78    | 38.5  | 2    | 3    | 5     | 40.0  |
| <b>Payment for sex is main source of income</b>             |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                         | 8    | 8    | 16    | 50.0  | 6    | 7    | 13    | 46.2  |
| No                                                          | 54   | 93   | 147   | 36.7  | 7    | 5    | 12    | 58.3  |
| <b>Condom use the last time you were paid money for sex</b> |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                         | 51   | 87   | 138   | 37.0  | 11   | 7    | 18    | 61.1  |
| No                                                          | 10   | 14   | 24    | 41.7  | 2    | 5    | 7     | 28.6  |
| <b>Ever paid money for sex</b>                              |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                         | 30   | 53   | 83    | 36.1  | 5    | 3    | 8     | 62.5  |
| No                                                          | 94   | 281  | 375   | 25.1  | 17   | 16   | 33    | 51.5  |
| <b>Ever received help with housing or expenses for sex</b>  |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                         | 29   | 70   | 99    | 29.3  | 8    | 10   | 18    | 44.4  |
| No                                                          | 95   | 264  | 359   | 26.5  | 14   | 9    | 23    | 60.9  |

## SEXUALLY TRANSMITTED INFECTIONS

Many participants had ever been told by a health care worker that they had a sexually transmitted infection (STI) (MSM 50.3%, TGW 56.1%) (Table 24). More than one fifth of participants had been told that they had an STI in the past 12 months (MSM 22.0%, TGW 22.0%). Within the past 3 months 7.6% of MSM reported having a genital discharge, 4.6% a genital ulcer, 2% a genital wart and 9.6% burning when passing urine. Among TGW three (3) reported a genital discharge within the past 3 months, one (1) a genital ulcer, two (2) a genital wart and two (2) burning when passing urine. Among participants reporting STI symptoms within the past 3 months 39.0% of MSM and one (1) TGW said that they had sex while having symptoms. Most MSM (81.0%) and TGW (87.8%) said that they had ever been to a public health clinic.

**TABLE 24: SEXUALLY TRANSMITTED INFECTIONS (STI) AMONG MSM AND TGW IN JAMAICA 2024**

|                                                         | MSM  |      |      |       |       | TGW  |      |       |       |
|---------------------------------------------------------|------|------|------|-------|-------|------|------|-------|-------|
|                                                         | %    | HIV+ | HIV- | Total | % +ve | HIV+ | HIV- | Total | % +ve |
| Ever told by health worker you have an STI              |      |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                     | 50.3 | 104  | 127  | 231   | 45.0  | 16   | 7    | 23    | 69.6  |
| No                                                      | 49.7 | 19   | 208  | 227   | 8.4   | 6    | 12   | 18    | 33.3  |
| In past 12 months told by health worker you have an STI |      |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                     | 22.0 | 43   | 58   | 101   | 42.6  | 6    | 3    | 9     | 66.7  |
| No                                                      | 88.0 | 80   | 277  | 357   | 22.4  | 16   | 16   | 32    | 50.0  |
| Genital discharge in past 3 months                      |      |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                     | 7.6  | 8    | 27   | 35    | 22.8  | 1    | 2    | 3     | 3.3   |
| No                                                      | 92.4 | 116  | 308  | 424   | 27.4  | 21   | 17   | 38    | 55.3  |
| Genital ulcer in past 3 months                          |      |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                     | 4.6  | 7    | 14   | 21    | 33.3  | 1    | 0    | 1     | 100   |
| No                                                      | 95.4 | 117  | 321  | 438   | 26.7  | 21   | 19   | 40    | 52.5  |
| Burning on passing urine in past 3 months               |      |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                     | 9.6  | 12   | 32   | 44    | 27.3  | 0    | 2    | 2     | 0     |
| No                                                      | 98.0 | 112  | 303  | 415   | 27.   | 22   | 16   | 38    | 57.9  |
| Had sex while had symptoms                              |      |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                     | 39.0 | 6    | 24   | 30    | 20.0  | 0    | 1    | 1     | 0     |
| No                                                      | 61.0 | 12   | 35   | 47    | 25.5  | 2    | 3    | 5     | 40.0  |
| Ever been to a public health clinic                     |      |      |      |       |       |      |      |       |       |
| Yes                                                     | 81.0 | 106  | 268  | 374   | 28.3  | 18   | 18   | 36    | 50.0  |
| No                                                      | 19.0 | 18   | 67   | 85    | 21.2  | 4    | 1    | 5     | 80.0  |

All participants except nine (9) MSM (98%) said they knew where to go to get an HIV test. Nearly all participants (94%) said it was easy to access an HIV test and 95% said that they had ever been tested. 79% of MSM and 56% of TGW had done an HIV test within the past 12 months and nearly all (96%) of them received their result and most (80%) were counselled.

More than half of the persons tested shared their result with their main partner (MSM 51%, TGW 55%) and many shared their result with a friend or co-worker (MSM 51%, TGW 42%). Most participants (MSM 71.5%, TGW 75.6%) had heard of the HIV self-testing kit and one third (MSM 33.2%, TGW 38.7%) had ever used it.

### ***SUBSTANCE USE***

Among participants, 8% said that they have a daily drink of alcohol, 21% said they drank weekly and 71% said that they drank less than weekly or never. When asked if they recalled any occasion in the past 4 weeks where six (6) or more alcoholic drinks were consumed 33% of MSM and 25% of TGW said yes. No participant had used crack/ cocaine or injected drugs in the past 6 months while 5% of MSM and 10% of TGW had used ecstasy. 37% of MSM and 44% of TGW reported using some other drug in the past 6 months. Marijuana use was common.

### ***LIFE CHALLENGES***

Participants were asked about specific issues and whether they were a big problem, small problem or not a problem. Not having a good place to live was a big problem for 40% of MSM and 74% of TGW as was not getting enough food (MSM 29%, TGW 49%) and unemployment (MSM 36%, TGW 66%). 14% of MSM and 34% of TGW said that transportation was a big problem and 15% of MSM and 7% of TGW said that health problems were a big problem. Getting HIV infection was a big problem for 41% of MSM and 61% of TGW. Stigma from family and friends was a big problem for 26% of MSM and 46% of TGW, a small problem for 22% of MSM and 15% of TGW and not a problem for 52% of MSM and 39% of TGW. Being rejected by their family was a big problem (MSM 30%, TGW 66%), as was being abused due to their sexual orientation (MSM 32%, TGW 71%) and being attacked because of sexual orientation (MSM 31%, TGW 68%).

### ***KNOWLEDGE***

Most MSM (58.8%) and TGW (56.1%) were able to answer all five (5) knowledge questions about HIV correctly (Table 25). All TGW and nearly all MSM knew that a healthy-looking person can be infected with HIV while nearly all participants (TGW 95.1%, MSM 93.9%) knew that using condoms reduce the risk of HIV transmission.

**TABLE 25: HIV KNOWLEDGE AMONG MSM AND TGW IN JAMAICA 2024**

|                                                                                               | MSM Facility |      | MSM Outreach |      | MSM ALL |      | TG ALL |      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|--------------|------|---------|------|--------|------|
|                                                                                               | N            | %    | N            | %    | N       | %    | N      | %    |
| <b>Do you think that using condoms reduce the risk of HIV transmission?</b>                   |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Yes                                                                                           | 181          | 93.8 | 250          | 94.0 | 431     | 93.9 | 39     | 95.1 |
| No                                                                                            | 12           | 6.2  | 15           | 5.6  | 27      | 5.9  | 2      | 4.9  |
| Does Not Know                                                                                 | 0            | 0.0  | 1            | 0.4  | 1       | 0.2  | 0      | 0.0  |
| <b>Do you think that a healthy-looking person can be infected with HIV?</b>                   |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Yes                                                                                           | 189          | 97.9 | 258          | 97.0 | 447     | 97.4 | 41     | 100  |
| No                                                                                            | 4            | 2.1  | 7            | 2.6  | 11      | 2.4  | 0      | 0.0  |
| Does Not Know                                                                                 | 0            | 0.0  | 1            | 0.4  | 1       | 0.2  | 0      | 0.0  |
| <b>Do you think that a person can get HIV from mosquito bites?</b>                            |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Yes                                                                                           | 18           | 9.3  | 39           | 14.7 | 57      | 12.4 | 4      | 9.8  |
| No                                                                                            | 163          | 84.5 | 213          | 80.1 | 376     | 81.9 | 37     | 90.2 |
| Does Not Know                                                                                 | 12           | 6.2  | 14           | 5.3  | 26      | 5.7  | 0      | 0.0  |
| <b>Do you think that a person can get HIV by sharing a meal with someone who is infected?</b> |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Yes                                                                                           | 17           | 8.8  | 44           | 16.5 | 61      | 13.3 | 3      | 7.3  |
| No                                                                                            | 171          | 88.6 | 213          | 80.1 | 384     | 83.7 | 37     | 90.2 |
| Does Not Know                                                                                 | 5            | 2.6  | 9            | 3.4  | 14      | 3.1  | 1      | 2.4  |
| <b>Does having sex with only one faithful, uninfected partner reduce the risk of HIV?</b>     |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Yes                                                                                           | 165          | 85.5 | 217          | 81.6 | 382     | 83.2 | 29     | 70.7 |
| No                                                                                            | 26           | 13.5 | 47           | 17.7 | 73      | 15.9 | 11     | 26.8 |
| Does Not Know                                                                                 | 2            | 1.0  | 2            | 0.8  | 4       | 0.9  | 1      | 2.4  |
| <b>Answers 5 Knowledge Questions Correctly</b>                                                |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| No                                                                                            | 71           | 36.8 | 118          | 44.4 | 189     | 41.2 | 18     | 43.9 |
| Yes                                                                                           | 122          | 63.2 | 148          | 55.6 | 270     | 58.8 | 23     | 56.1 |

There was no clear association between knowledge of HIV and HIV prevalence although the prevalence was higher among MSM who think that condoms do not reduce the risk of HIV transmission (40.7% vs 26.2%) (Table 26).

**Table 26: Knowledge and HIV Status among MSM and TG Study Participants**

|                                                                                        | MSM       |           |            | TG        |           |            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|------------|-----------|-----------|------------|
|                                                                                        | N<br>HIV+ | %HIV<br>+ | All<br>MSM | N<br>HIV+ | %HIV<br>+ | ALL<br>TGW |
| All                                                                                    | 124       | 27.0      | 459        | 22        | 53.7      | 41         |
| Do you think that using condoms reduce the risk of HIV transmission?                   |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Yes                                                                                    | 113       | 26.2      | 431        | 21        | 53.8      | 39         |
| No                                                                                     | 11        | 40.7      | 27         | 1         | 50.0      | 2          |
| Does Not Know                                                                          | .         | .         | 1          |           |           |            |
| Do you think that a healthy-looking person can be infected with HIV?                   |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Yes                                                                                    | 121       | 27.1      | 447        | 22        | 53.7      | 41         |
| No                                                                                     | 3         | 27.3      | 11         |           |           |            |
| Does Not Know                                                                          | .         | .         | 1          |           |           |            |
| Do you think that a person can get HIV from mosquito bites?                            |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Yes                                                                                    | 13        | 22.8      | 57         | 2         | 50.0      | 4          |
| No                                                                                     | 104       | 27.7      | 376        | 20        | 54.1      | 37         |
| Does Not Know                                                                          | 7         | 26.9      | 26         |           |           |            |
| Do you think that a person can get HIV by sharing a meal with someone who is infected? |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Yes                                                                                    | 17        | 27.9      | 61         | 2         | 66.7      | 3          |
| No                                                                                     | 105       | 27.3      | 384        | 19        | 51.4      | 37         |
| Does Not Know                                                                          | 2         | 14.3      | 14         | 1         | 100.0     | 1          |
| Does having sex with only one faithful, uninfected partner can reduce the risk of HIV? |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Yes                                                                                    | 97        | 25.4      | 382        | 14        | 48.3      | 29         |
| No                                                                                     | 25        | 34.2      | 73         | 8         | 72.7      | 11         |
| Does Not Know                                                                          | 2         | 50.0      | 4          | .         | .         | 1          |
| Answers all 5 Knowledge Questions Correctly                                            |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| No                                                                                     | 56        | 39.6      | 189        | 11        | 61.1      | 18         |
| Yes                                                                                    | 68        | 25.2      | 270        | 11        | 47.8      | 23         |

**STIGMA**

One third of MSM (30.1%) were not comfortable telling anyone that they have sex with men and another one third (34.6%) were comfortable telling less than half the persons they knew (Table 27). More TGW (36.6%) than MSM (12.4%) were comfortable telling anyone that they have sex with men. Among all participants, 26.8% of TGW and 9.2% of MSM said that in the past year they had been treated badly by a health care worker in a public clinic and as many as 24.4% of TGW and 17.7% of MSM had avoided seeking care because they were worried that they may be treated badly. Stigma from health care workers was not considered a problem by 80.4% of MSM and 61.0% of TGW. However, 39.1% of TGW and 19.6% of MSM considered stigma from health care workers to be either a big or small problem.

**TABLE 27: REPORTED STIGMA FROM HEALTH CARE WORKERS AMONG MSM AND TGW**

|                                                                                                     | MSM Facility |      | MSM Outreach |      | MSM All |      | TG ALL |      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|--------------|------|---------|------|--------|------|
|                                                                                                     | N            | %    | N            | %    | N       | %    | N      | %    |
| How comfortable are you telling people you have sex with men?                                       |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Not comfortable with telling anyone                                                                 | 41           | 21.2 | 97           | 36.5 | 138     | 30.1 | 10     | 24.4 |
| Comfortable with <half the people you know                                                          | 81           | 42.0 | 78           | 29.3 | 159     | 34.6 | 7      | 17.1 |
| Comfortable with half the people you know                                                           | 29           | 15.0 | 47           | 17.7 | 76      | 16.6 | 5      | 12.2 |
| Comfortable with >half the people you know                                                          | 16           | 8.3  | 13           | 4.9  | 29      | 6.3  | 4      | 9.8  |
| Comfortable telling anyone                                                                          | 26           | 13.5 | 31           | 11.7 | 57      | 12.4 | 15     | 36.6 |
| In the past year, been treated badly by a health care worker (HCW) in a public clinic               |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Did not attend public clinic in past year                                                           | 49           | 25.4 | 36           | 13.5 | 85      | 18.5 | 5      | 12.2 |
| Yes                                                                                                 | 16           | 8.3  | 26           | 9.8  | 42      | 9.2  | 11     | 26.8 |
| No                                                                                                  | 127          | 65.8 | 204          | 76.7 | 331     | 72.1 | 25     | 61.0 |
| Don't Know                                                                                          | 1            | 0.5  | 0            | 0.0  | 1       | 0.2  | 0      | 0.0  |
| In past year avoided seeking health care at public clinic because worried HCW would treat you badly |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Yes                                                                                                 | 42           | 21.8 | 39           | 14.7 | 81      | 17.7 | 10     | 24.4 |
| No                                                                                                  | 151          | 78.2 | 227          | 85.3 | 378     | 82.4 | 31     | 75.6 |
| Stigma from health care workers?                                                                    |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Big Problem                                                                                         | 18           | 9.3  | 26           | 9.8  | 44      | 9.6  | 7      | 17.1 |
| Small Problem                                                                                       | 23           | 11.9 | 23           | 8.7  | 46      | 10.0 | 9      | 22.0 |
| Not A Problem                                                                                       | 152          | 78.8 | 217          | 81.6 | 369     | 80.4 | 25     | 61.0 |

Stigma from families and friends was considered a big problem among 46.3% of TGW and 25.7% of MSM while 39.0% of TGW and 52.1% of MSM did not consider it a problem (Table 28). Being rejected by their family was a much bigger problem among TGW (65.9%) than MSM (30.3%). This was not a problem for 47.7% of MSM and 17.1% of TGW. Being abused because of sexual orientation was a big problem for most TGW (70.7%) and nearly one third of MSM (31.6%). Being physically attacked because of sexual orientation was a big problem for most TGW (68.3%) and 30.5% of MSM. This was not a problem for 52.3% of MSM and 19.5% of TGW.

**TABLE 28: REPORTED STIGMA FROM FAMILY AND FRIENDS AMONG MSM AND TGW**

| How big a problem is                                          | MSM Facility |      | MSM Outreach |      | MSM All |      | TG ALL |      |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|--------------|------|---------|------|--------|------|
|                                                               | N            | %    | N            | %    | N       | %    | N      | %    |
| Stigma from family and friends?                               |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Big Problem                                                   | 49           | 25.4 | 69           | 25.9 | 118     | 25.7 | 19     | 46.3 |
| Small Problem                                                 | 45           | 23.3 | 56           | 21.1 | 101     | 22.0 | 6      | 14.6 |
| Not A Problem                                                 | 99           | 51.3 | 140          | 52.6 | 239     | 52.1 | 16     | 39.0 |
| Refused                                                       | 0            | 0.0  | 1            | 0.4  | 1       | 0.2  | 0      | 0.0  |
| Being rejected by your family?                                |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Big Problem                                                   | 55           | 28.5 | 84           | 31.6 | 139     | 30.3 | 27     | 65.9 |
| Small Problem                                                 | 45           | 23.3 | 55           | 20.7 | 100     | 21.8 | 7      | 17.1 |
| Not A Problem                                                 | 92           | 47.7 | 127          | 47.7 | 219     | 47.7 | 7      | 17.1 |
| Don't Know                                                    | 1            | 0.5  | 0            | 0.0  | 1       | 0.2  | 0      | 0.0  |
| Being abused because of sexual orientation?                   |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Big Problem                                                   | 60           | 31.1 | 85           | 32.0 | 145     | 31.6 | 29     | 70.7 |
| Small Problem                                                 | 38           | 19.7 | 45           | 16.9 | 83      | 18.1 | 5      | 12.2 |
| Not A Problem                                                 | 95           | 49.2 | 136          | 51.1 | 231     | 50.3 | 7      | 17.1 |
| Being physically attacked because of your sexual orientation? |              |      |              |      |         |      |        |      |
| Big Problem                                                   | 60           | 31.1 | 80           | 30.1 | 140     | 30.5 | 28     | 68.3 |
| Small Problem                                                 | 38           | 19.7 | 41           | 15.4 | 79      | 17.2 | 5      | 12.2 |
| Not A Problem                                                 | 95           | 49.2 | 145          | 54.5 | 240     | 52.3 | 8      | 19.5 |

HIV prevalence among MSM married or living with a woman (13.8%) was lower than among MSM married or living with a man (38.9%) or MSM who were not living with either a woman or a man (26.3%) (Table 29). HIV prevalence did not appear to vary significantly among MSM or TGW with different levels of comfort in revealing that they had sex with men or experience of stigma from a health care worker.

**Table 29: STIGMA AND HIV STATUS AMONG MSM AND TGW STUDY PARTICIPANTS**

|                                                                                                                                                    | MSM       |           |            | TG        |           |            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|------------|-----------|-----------|------------|
|                                                                                                                                                    | N<br>HIV+ | %<br>HIV+ | All<br>MSM | N<br>HIV+ | %<br>HIV+ | ALL<br>TGW |
| All                                                                                                                                                | 124       | 27.0      | 459        | 22        | 53.7      | 41         |
| Married to or living with                                                                                                                          |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Married or living with a woman                                                                                                                     | 4         | 13.8      | 29         |           |           |            |
| Married or living with a man                                                                                                                       | 21        | 38.9      | 54         | 6         | 60.0      | 10         |
| Neither                                                                                                                                            | 99        | 26.3      | 376        | 16        | 51.6      | 31         |
| How comfortable are you about telling people you have sex with men?                                                                                |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Not comfortable with telling anyone                                                                                                                | 41        | 39.7      | 138        | 3         | 30.0      | 10         |
| Comfortable with <half the people you know                                                                                                         | 41        | 25.8      | 159        | 4         | 57.1      | 7          |
| Comfortable with half the people you know                                                                                                          | 20        | 26.3      | 76         | 3         | 60.0      | 5          |
| Comfortable with >half the people you know                                                                                                         | 4         | 13.8      | 29         | 2         | 50.0      | 4          |
| Comfortable Telling Anyone                                                                                                                         | 18        | 31.6      | 57         | 10        | 66.7      | 15         |
| If yes, in the past year, have you been treated badly by a health care worker in a public clinic?                                                  |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Did not attend public clinic in past year                                                                                                          | 18        | 21.2      | 85         | 4         | 80.0      | 5          |
| Yes                                                                                                                                                | 13        | 31.0      | 42         | 9         | 81.8      | 11         |
| No                                                                                                                                                 | 92        | 27.8      | 331        | 9         | 36.0      | 25         |
| Don't Know                                                                                                                                         | 1         | 100.0     | 1          |           |           |            |
| In the past year, have you avoided seeking health care at a public clinic because you were worried that health care workers would treat you badly? |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Yes                                                                                                                                                | 24        | 29.6      | 81         | 6         | 60.0      | 10         |
| No                                                                                                                                                 | 100       | 26.5      | 378        | 16        | 51.6      | 31         |
| Stigma from health care workers?                                                                                                                   |           |           |            |           |           |            |
| Big Problem                                                                                                                                        | 17        | 38.6      | 44         | 4         | 57.1      | 7          |
| Small Problem                                                                                                                                      | 13        | 28.3      | 46         | 5         | 55.6      | 9          |
| Not A Problem                                                                                                                                      | 94        | 25.5      | 369        | 13        | 52.0      | 25         |

HIV prevalence was higher among TGW than MSM regardless of whether stigma and/ or rejection from family and friends was a big problem or not (Table 30).

**Table 30: STIGMA AND HIV STATUS AMONG MSM AND TGW STUDY PARTICIPANTS**

|                                                  | MSM       |        |            | TG        |           |            |
|--------------------------------------------------|-----------|--------|------------|-----------|-----------|------------|
|                                                  | N<br>HIV+ | % HIV+ | All<br>MSM | N<br>HIV+ | %<br>HIV+ | ALL<br>TGW |
| All                                              | 124       | 27.0   | 459        | 22        | 53.7      | 41         |
| Stigma from family and friends?                  |           |        |            |           |           |            |
| Big Problem                                      | 32        | 27.1   | 118        | 8         | 42.1      | 19         |
| Small Problem                                    | 28        | 27.7   | 101        | 3         | 50.0      | 6          |
| Not A Problem                                    | 63        | 26.3   | 239        | 11        | 68.8      | 16         |
| Refused                                          | 1         | 100.0  | 1          |           |           |            |
| Being rejected by your family?                   |           |        |            |           |           |            |
| Big Problem                                      | 34        | 24.5   | 139        | 11        | 40.7      | 27         |
| Small Problem                                    | 28        | 28.0   | 100        | 7         | 100       | 7          |
| Not A Problem                                    | 62        | 28.3   | 219        | 4         | 57.1      | 7          |
| Don't Know                                       | .         | .      | 1          |           |           |            |
| Being abused because of your sexual orientation? |           |        |            |           |           |            |
| Big Problem                                      | 50        | 34.5   | 145        | 13        | 44.8      | 29         |
| Small Problem                                    | 20        | 24.1   | 83         | 4         | 80.0      | 5          |
| Not A Problem                                    | 54        | 23.4   | 231        | 5         | 71.4      | 7          |

**Violence**

A higher proportion of TGW than MSM said that their partner insulted or embarrassed them or hit or choked them often or occasionally (Table 31). Approximately 10% of TGW and MSM said that their partner had occasionally raped or forced them to have sex. As many as 53.7% of TGW and 25.7% of MSM reported that they had ever been raped.

**Table 31: REPORTED VIOLENCE AMONG MSM AND TGW SURVEY PARTICIPANTS JAMAICA**

|                                                                                   | MSM<br>Facility |      | MSM<br>Outreach |      | MSM All |      | TG ALL |      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|------|-----------------|------|---------|------|--------|------|
|                                                                                   | N               | %    | N               | %    | N       | %    | N      | %    |
| How frequently does your partner insult, harass, embarrass or try to control you? |                 |      |                 |      |         |      |        |      |
| Never                                                                             | 125             | 64.8 | 170             | 63.9 | 295     | 64.3 | 19     | 46.3 |
| Occasionally                                                                      | 35              | 18.1 | 50              | 18.8 | 85      | 18.5 | 6      | 14.6 |
| Often                                                                             | 13              | 6.7  | 19              | 7.1  | 32      | 7.0  | 12     | 29.3 |
| No Partner                                                                        | 20              | 10.4 | 27              | 10.2 | 47      | 10.2 | 4      | 9.8  |
| How frequently does your partner slap, hit or choke you?                          |                 |      |                 |      |         |      |        |      |
| Never                                                                             | 151             | 78.2 | 200             | 75.2 | 351     | 76.5 | 23     | 56.1 |
| Occasionally                                                                      | 15              | 7.8  | 33              | 12.4 | 48      | 10.5 | 10     | 24.4 |
| Often                                                                             | 7               | 3.6  | 6               | 2.3  | 13      | 2.8  | 4      | 9.8  |
| No Partner                                                                        | 20              | 10.4 | 27              | 10.2 | 47      | 10.2 | 4      | 9.8  |
| How frequently has your partner raped or forced you to have sex?                  |                 |      |                 |      |         |      |        |      |
| Never                                                                             | 155             | 80.3 | 206             | 77.4 | 361     | 78.7 | 31     | 75.6 |
| Occasionally                                                                      | 15              | 7.8  | 30              | 11.3 | 45      | 9.8  | 4      | 9.8  |
| Often                                                                             | 2               | 1.0  | 3               | 1.1  | 5       | 1.1  | 2      | 4.9  |
| No Partner                                                                        | 21              | 10.9 | 27              | 10.2 | 48      | 10.5 | 4      | 9.8  |
| Have you ever been raped?                                                         |                 |      |                 |      |         |      |        |      |
| Yes                                                                               | 47              | 24.4 | 71              | 26.7 | 118     | 25.7 | 22     | 53.7 |
| No                                                                                | 146             | 75.7 | 193             | 72.6 | 339     | 73.9 | 19     | 46.3 |
| Don't Know                                                                        | 0               | 0.0  | 2               | 0.8  | 2       | 0.4  | 0      | 0.0  |

Nearly a fifth (18.5%) of MSM said that their partner occasionally insulted, embarrassed or tried to control them while 7% said that their partner did this often (Table 32). Only a few MSM said that their partner often slapped, threatened them with a weapon or raped them while approximately 10% of MSM said that their partner did this occasionally. As many as 25.7% of MSM and 53.7% of TGW reported ever being raped. HIV prevalence was higher among MSM who ever reported being raped than those who were never raped (38.1% vs 22.7%).

**Table 32: VIOLENCE AND HIV STATUS AMONG MSM AND TG STUDY PARTICIPANTS**

|                                                                                   | MSM  |       |     | TG   |      |     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|-------|-----|------|------|-----|
|                                                                                   | N    | %     | All | N    | %    | ALL |
|                                                                                   | HIV+ | HIV+  | MSM | HIV+ | HIV+ | TGW |
| All                                                                               | 124  | 27.0  | 459 | 22   | 53.7 | 41  |
| How frequently does your partner insult, harass, embarrass or try to control you? |      |       |     |      |      |     |
| Never                                                                             | 80   | 27.1  | 295 | 9    | 47.4 | 19  |
| Occasionally                                                                      | 17   | 20.0  | 85  | 4    | 66.7 | 6   |
| Often                                                                             | 9    | 28.1  | 32  | 6    | 50.0 | 12  |
| No Partner                                                                        | 18   | 38.3  | 47  | 3    | 75.0 | 4   |
| How frequently does your partner slap, hit or choke you?                          |      |       |     |      |      |     |
| Never                                                                             | 90   | 25.6  | 351 | 10   | 43.5 | 23  |
| Occasionally                                                                      | 13   | 27.1  | 48  | 6    | 60.0 | 10  |
| Often                                                                             | 3    | 23.1  | 13  | 3    | 75.0 | 4   |
| No Partner                                                                        | 18   | 38.3  | 47  | 3    | 75.0 | 4   |
| How frequently had your partner threatened you with any kind of weapon?           |      |       |     |      |      |     |
| Never                                                                             | 91   | 25.6  | 35  | 14   | 51.9 | 27  |
| Occasionally                                                                      | 11   | 23.4  | 47  | 3    | 42.9 | 7   |
| Often                                                                             | 4    | 44.4  | 9   | 2    | 66.7 | 3   |
| No Partner                                                                        | 18   | 38.3  | 47  | 3    | 75.0 | 4   |
| How frequently has your partner raped or forced you to have sex?                  |      |       |     |      |      |     |
| Never                                                                             | 93   | 25.8  | 361 | 15   | 48.4 | 31  |
| Occasionally                                                                      | 13   | 28.9  | 45  | 3    | 75.0 | 4   |
| Often                                                                             | .    | .     | 5   | 1    | 50.0 | 2   |
| No Partner                                                                        | 18   | 37.5  | 48  | 3    | 75.0 | 4   |
| Have you ever been raped?                                                         |      |       |     |      |      |     |
| Yes                                                                               | 45   | 38.1  | 118 | 11   | 50.0 | 22  |
| No                                                                                | 77   | 22.7  | 339 | 11   | 57.9 | 19  |
| Don't Know                                                                        | 2    | 100.0 | 2   |      |      |     |

Factors that appear to be protective against HIV for MSM were ever taking PrEP, completing high school or tertiary education, and aged 16 years or older at first sex (Table 33).

**Table 33: PROTECTIVE PROXIMATE DETERMINANTS AMONG MSM BY HIV STATUS & PREVALENCE RATIOS WITH 95% CI**

|                      | HIV+/total | % HIV+ | 95% CI      | Prevalence ratio | 95% CI      |
|----------------------|------------|--------|-------------|------------------|-------------|
| Ever taken PrEP?     |            |        |             |                  |             |
| Yes                  | 14/117     | 12.0   | 5.3 – 18.6  | 0.37             | 0.20 - 0.69 |
| No                   | 110/342    | 32.2   | 25.6 – 38.8 |                  |             |
| Educational level    |            |        |             |                  |             |
| < High school        | 22/43      | 51.2   | 38.7 – 63.6 | 0.48             | 0.36 – 0.65 |
| High school/tertiary | 102/416    | 24.5   | 20.0 – 25.0 |                  |             |
| Age at first sex     |            |        |             |                  |             |
| 16+                  | 75/319     | 23.5   | 18.0 – 29.1 | 0.67             | 0.45 – 0.98 |
| <16 years            | 49/139     | 35.2   | 25.5 – 45.0 |                  |             |

### Post-Exposure Prophylaxis

Only 62 MSM (13.5%) and 7 TGW (17.1%) had ever taken post-exposure prophylaxis (PEP). Most MSM (286, 62.3%) and TGW (25, 61.0%) had never taken PEP and 111 MSM (24.2%) and 9 TGW (22.0%) had never heard of it.

### Risk Factors for HIV infection among MSM

Risk factors significantly associated with HIV infection in MSM were being told by a health provider that they ever had a STI, or having a STI in the past 12 months, ever raped, ever spent a night in jail or prison, ever homeless, ever violently attacked by a sexual partner, ever receiving money for sex or receiving money for sex in the past six (6) months (Table 34). Being sexually abused as a child, not completing high school and having sex with a man before the age of 16 years were also likely to be risk factors for HIV infection among MSM. The prevalence ratio for ever being told by a health provider that they had a STI was 4.5, 95% CI 2.8 – 7.3.

**Table 34: RISK FACTORS ASSOCIATED WITH HIV INFECTION AMONG MSM AND PREVALENCE RATIOS WITH 95% CI**

|                                         | HIV+/total | % HIV+ | 95% CI      | Prevalence ratio | 95% CI    |
|-----------------------------------------|------------|--------|-------------|------------------|-----------|
| Ever told STI                           |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 103/231    | 44.6   | 38.2 – 50.9 | 4.5              | 2.8 – 7.3 |
| No                                      | 19/191     | 9.9    | 5.6 – 14.3  |                  |           |
| STI past 12 months                      |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 43/101     | 42.6   | 32.8 – 52.4 | 1.9              | 1.3 – 2.6 |
| No                                      | 80/357     | 22.4   | 17.5 – 27.4 |                  |           |
| Ever raped (Q125)                       |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 45/118     | 38.1   | 30.0 – 46.3 | 1.7              | 1.2 – 2.3 |
| No                                      | 77/339     | 22.7   | 17.4 – 28.0 |                  |           |
| Ever in Jail or prison                  |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 42/113     | 37.2   | 29.5 – 44.8 | 1.6              | 1.1 – 2.1 |
| No                                      | 82/346     | 23.7   | 18.1 – 29.3 |                  |           |
| Ever homeless                           |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 50/132     | 37.9   | 29.1 – 46.6 | 1.7              | 1.2 – 2.3 |
| No                                      | 74/327     | 23.5   | 17.7 – 27.6 |                  |           |
| Ever violently attacked by partner      |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 46/127     | 36.2   | 28.5 – 44.0 | 1.5              | 1.2 – 1.9 |
| No                                      | 78/332     | 23.5   | 19.0 – 28.0 |                  |           |
| Sexually abused as child                |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 44/130     | 33.8   | 24.9 – 42.8 | 1.4              | 1.0 – 2.0 |
| No                                      | 80/327     | 24.3   | 19.0 – 29.6 |                  |           |
| Ever received money for sex             |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 62/163     | 38.0   | 28.9 – 47.1 | 1.8              | 1.2 – 2.7 |
| No                                      | 62/296     | 20.9   | 15.4 - 26.4 |                  |           |
| Received money for sex in past 6 months |            |        |             |                  |           |
| Yes                                     | 32/85      | 37.6   | 25.8 - 49.5 | 1.5              | 1.1 – 2.2 |
| No                                      | 92/374     | 24.6   | 20.3 – 28.9 |                  |           |

### **ANTI-RETROVIRAL TREATMENT (ART)**

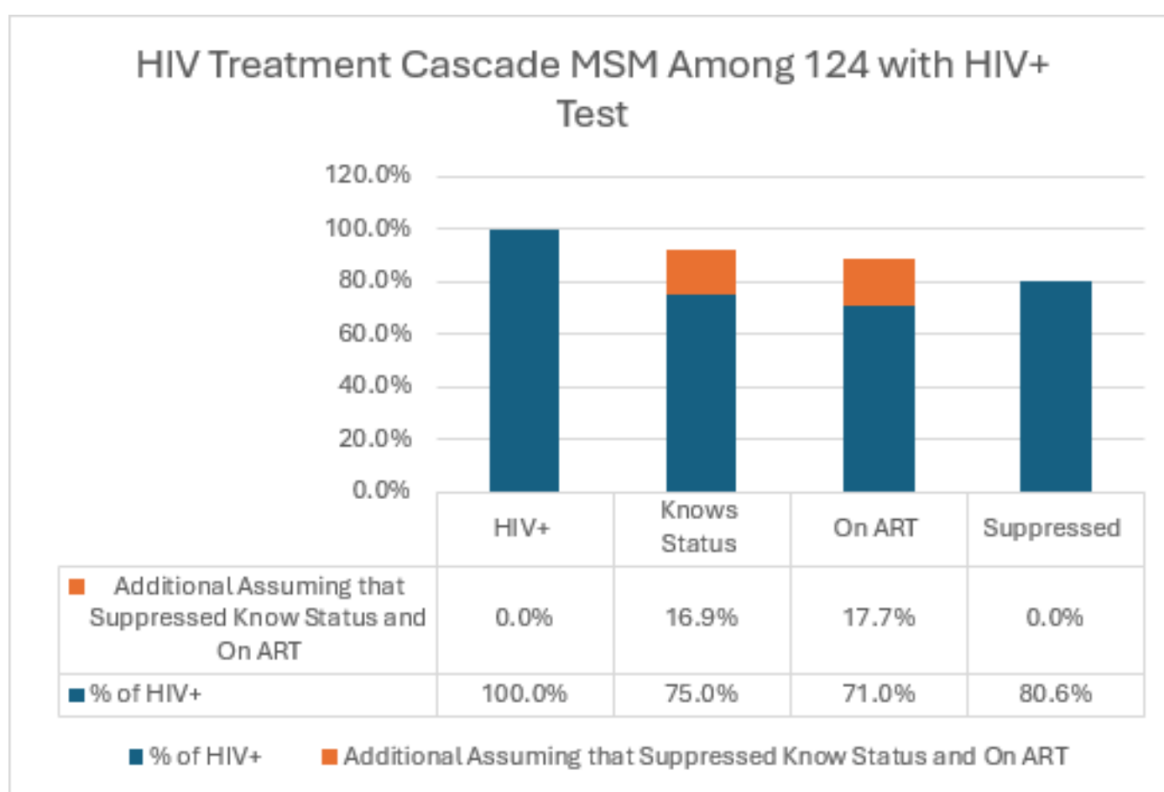
A total of 146 (29.2%) of the 500 participants tested HIV positive; 124 (27.0%) of 459 MSM and 22 (53.7%) of 41 TGW. Of the 146 participants testing HIV positive 107 (73.2%, 93 MSM 14 TGW) self-reported that they were HIV positive. An additional 26 participants (21 MSM and 5 TGW) denied being HIV positive but had viral loads <1000 copies which suggests that they were on treatment and virally suppressed although they did not indicate that they were HIV positive or on treatment. Table 35 presents the HIV treatment cascade for MSM both with and without the assumption that if the viral load is suppressed (<1000 copies) the MSM knows his status and is on ART. Without this assumption, 75% of the MSM in the survey knew their HIV status, 71% were on ART and 100 of 124 (80.6%) were virally suppressed. With this assumption, 91.9% of MSM in the survey knew their status, 88.7% were on treatment and 80.6% were virally suppressed. This latter scenario is more likely to be reflecting the actual situation.

**Table 35: HIV TREATMENT CASCADE FOR MSM**

| <b>MSM<br/>weighted %</b> | <b>Without assumption: if suppressed,<br/>MSM knows status &amp; is on ART</b> |      |            | <b>With assumption: if suppressed,<br/>MSM knows status and is on ART</b> |      |            |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|------------|
|                           | N                                                                              | %    | 95% CI     | N                                                                         | %    | 95% CI     |
| HIV +ve                   | 124                                                                            | 100  |            | 124                                                                       | 100  |            |
| Knows status              | 93                                                                             | 75   | 66.2, 84.8 | 114                                                                       | 91.9 | 86.4, 97.1 |
| On ART                    | 88                                                                             | 71   | 61.1, 80.8 | 110                                                                       | 88.7 | 83.1, 94.3 |
| Suppressed                | 100                                                                            | 80.6 | 72.8, 88.4 | 100                                                                       | 80.6 | 72.9, 88.4 |

When participants were asked the result of their most recent HIV test 91 (19.8%) MSM and 13 (31.7%) TGW said they tested HIV positive. 91 MSM and 14 TGW said that they ever started Anti-retroviral treatment (ART) and 88 MSM and 14 TGW said they were currently on treatment. Adherence in the past month was daily for 41 MSM and 5 TGW while 27 MSM and 8 TGW missed medication once weekly or less. 17 MSM and one (1) TGW missed ART more than once a week and 3 MSM had not taken any medication in the past week.

The HIV treatment cascade is presented as a bar chart in Figure 2 showing the additional proportion of MSM who knew their HIV status and were on treatment given the assumption that if they were virally suppressed then they knew their status and were on treatment.



**FIGURE 2: HIV TREATMENT CASCADE AMONG 124 MSM in 2024**

HIV prevalence among MSM recruited through facilities was 21% compared with 32% among MSM recruited through outreach activities. However, the proportion of HIV positive MSM who were virally suppressed was similar for these two groups; 82.4% for those recruited through facilities and 80% for those recruited through outreach (Table 36).

**Table 36: PROPORTION OF HIV POSITIVE MSM VIRALLY SUPPRESSED BY MODE OF RECRUITMENT**

| Mode of recruitment | Total MSM recruited | No. HIV +ve | % HIV +ve | No. virally suppressed | % virally suppressed |
|---------------------|---------------------|-------------|-----------|------------------------|----------------------|
| Facility            | 193                 | 40          | 21%       | 33                     | 82.4%                |
| Outreach            | 266                 | 84          | 32%       | 67                     | 80%                  |

Of 41 TGW 22 (53.7%) were HIV positive. Without the assumption that if the viral load is suppressed (<1000 copies) the TGW knows her status and is on ART, 14 (63.6%) TGW knew their status, 14 (63.6%) were on treatment and (68.2%) were virally suppressed (Table 37). With this assumption 19 (86.4%) TGW knew their status, 19 (86.4%) were on treatment and 15 (68.2%) were virally suppressed.

**Table 37: HIV TREATMENT CASCADE for TGW**

| TGW unweighted % | Without assumption: if suppressed, TGW knows status & is on ART |      | With assumption: if suppressed, TGW knows status and is on ART |      |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------|
|                  | N                                                               | %    | N                                                              | %    |
| HIV +ve          | 22                                                              |      | 22                                                             |      |
| Knows status     | 14                                                              | 63.6 | 19                                                             | 86.4 |
| On ART           | 14                                                              | 63.6 | 19                                                             | 86.4 |
| Suppressed       | 15                                                              | 68.2 | 15                                                             | 68.2 |

A higher proportion of HIV positive MSM were virally suppressed (100 of 124 or 80.6%) than among TGW (15 of 22 or 68.2%) (Table 37). The proportion of HIV positive participants (MSM and TGW taken together) who were suppressed increased by age from 69.0% in persons 16-24 years, to 78.5% in 25-34 years and 84.6% in those 35 years or older (Table 38). Participants who had completed secondary education were more likely to be virally suppressed than those who had not (83.9% vs. 57.1%). Persons who accepted money for sex in the past 6 months were less likely to be virally suppressed than those who did not (60.5% vs. 86.4%). Those participants who had experienced more adverse life events were less likely to be virally suppressed as were persons who had been homeless or spent a night in jail or were of lower socio-economic status. Among participants seeking care at JASL 29 of 38 (76.3%) were virally suppressed.

**TABLE 38: PROPORTION OF HIV POSITIVE PARTICIPANTS (MSM & TGW) WHO WERE VIRALLY SUPPRESSED BY CHARACTERISTIC**

|                                   | No. virally suppressed | Total HIV +ve | % virally suppressed |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------|---------------|----------------------|
| MSM                               | 100                    | 124           | 80.6                 |
| TGW                               | 15                     | 22            | 68.2                 |
| AGE 16 – 24 years                 | 20                     | 29            | 69.0                 |
| 25 - 34                           | 51                     | 65            | 78.5                 |
| 35 +                              | 44                     | 52            | 84.6                 |
| Education < secondary             | 16                     | 28            | 57.1                 |
| Completed secondary               | 99                     | 118           | 83.9                 |
| Sex for money past 6 months: Yes  | 26                     | 43            | 60.5                 |
| No                                | 89                     | 103           | 86.4                 |
| # male sex partners past 4 wks: 0 | 17                     | 20            | 85.0                 |
| 1 – 4                             | 88                     | 111           | 79.3                 |
| 5 – 9                             | 7                      | 8             | 87.5                 |
| 10 +                              | 3                      | 7             | 42.9                 |
| Socio-economic status: 1 - 3      | 61                     | 83            | 73.5                 |
| 4 – 9                             | 54                     | 63            | 85.7                 |
| No. of adverse events: 0          | 22                     | 24            | 91.7                 |
| 1 - 3                             | 44                     | 56            | 78.6                 |
| 4 +                               | 49                     | 66            | 74.2                 |
| Ever homeless: Yes                | 47                     | 66            | 71.2                 |
| No                                | 68                     | 80            | 85.0                 |
| Ever in jail: Yes                 | 35                     | 51            | 68.6                 |
| No                                | 80                     | 95            | 84.2                 |

## **DISCUSSION**

HIV prevalence among MSM and TGW remains high in Jamaica in 2024 (MSM 27.0% 95% CI 22.9% - 31.6%, TGW 53.7% 95% CI 21.3% - 69.6%). HIV prevalence among MSM increases rapidly by age. Among MSM aged 16-19 years HIV prevalence was 10.7%, 20-24 years 14.2%, 25-29 years 29.0%, 30-34 years 32.4% and over the age of 40 years 40%. The stark reality is that we are failing to reduce the proportion of MSM and TGW getting HIV infected for the past 3 decades. The most encouraging sign is that the HIV prevalence among MSM using pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP) was 12.0% compared with 32.3% among those not using PrEP. A clear priority of the National HIV/STI Program must be to get many more MSM and TGW using PrEP at a young age.

It is also a concern that as many as 50.3% of participants reported that a health provider had ever told them that they had a STI and 22.0% were so informed in the past 12 months. HIV prevalence was high among persons reporting ever having a STI (MSM 45.0%, TGW 69.6%) or having a STI in the past 12 months (MSM 42.6%, TGW 66.7%). Nearly one third of participants tested positive for ever having syphilis (MSM 29.2%, TGW 51.2%). Ever having syphilis or another STI is a known risk factor for HIV infection. Ready access to prompt diagnosis and treatment of syphilis and other STIs is essential. Bioline testing should be routinely offered to all MSM and young adults at Accident and Emergency departments of hospitals, inner city health centres and NGOs providing services to MSM and TGW.

As found in previous surveys risk behaviour among MSM and TGW was common (1,5,7,8,9). There is no indication that sexual risk behaviour has become less frequent. Most participants reported three (3) or more sex partners in the past 12 months (MSM 59.8%, TGW 70.8%), two (2) or more partners in the past 4 weeks (MSM 31.9%, TGW 58.6%), and one (1) or more new sex partners in the past 4 weeks (MSM 34.2%, TGW 68.3%). As many as 37.6% of participants said that they had ever received cash for sex and 23.6% said that they had done so in the past 6 months. Among the latter, HIV prevalence was high (MSM 37.6%, TGW 55.0%).

Many participants suffered adverse life events as children and/or adults. As children, many were verbally abused (MSM 47.9%, TGW 63.4%), beaten (MSM 54.5%, TGW 68.3%) and/or sexually abused (MSM 28.4%, TGW 46.3%). One quarter of MSM (25.8%) and 53.7% of TGW had been raped while 28.8% of MSM and 73.2% of TGW had been homeless and 27.7% of MSM and 61.0% of TGW had ever been violently attacked by a sex partner. HIV prevalence was higher among MSM who had been raped (38.1%) or homeless (53.3%). Experiencing adverse life events was shown to be associated with increased HIV prevalence in the 2011 survey in Jamaica (8) and it appears to be the case in this survey also.

Stigma against MSM and particularly among TGW remains an important problem in Jamaica. TGW were more likely than MSM to be verbally abused, beaten or sexually abused as a child and raped, homeless, or ever attacked by a sex partner. Parents must be educated to recognize that beating and abusing children affects them negatively while praising good

behaviour and expressing love for your child promotes self-esteem and appropriate behaviour. There must be safe places established in schools and communities for MSM and TGW and counselors trained to offer support and guidance to them. It was encouraging to note that 81.5% of MSM and 87.8% of TGW had attended a public health clinic. However, 9.2% of MSM and 26.8% of TGW said that they had been treated badly by a health care worker in the past year and 17.7% of MSM and 24.4% of TGW said that they had avoided seeking health care at a public clinic because they were worried that they would be treated badly.

Recruitment of MSM and TGW for the survey was conducted at all known program sites in Jamaica providing targeted prevention services to MSM or TGW during the study period. When the prevention services were provided at a facility such as JASL or another NGO participants were recruited consecutively to reduce bias from interviewer preference. There was no recruitment at HIV treatment sites. When participants were recruited through prevention outreach activities all persons attending the workshop or outreach activity were approached to participate. Persons recruited through appointment cards and invitation letters given to participants were given an appointment to be interviewed and were included as outreach participants. Very few persons turned away prior to being approached (6) or refused to participate (4) though some persons (17) were ineligible. However, 40 persons had already participated and had to be turned away while 24 persons actively attempted to participate twice including using a different name.

HIV prevalence among MSM participants was significantly higher among MSM recruited at outreach activities than those recruited at NGO facilities. This may be because MSM recruited through outreach were more likely to report receiving cash for sex (40.2% vs 29.0%) and those recruited at service sites were more likely to be using PrEP (42.5% vs 13.2%). The socio-economic status, knowledge of HIV, number of sexual partners or adverse life events were similar between the two recruitment groups.

Five hundred (500) participants were recruited within 4 months, which was swifter than previous surveys. This was possible because NGOs and BCC officers in the field were very supportive in facilitating the survey and reaching prospective participants. The 876 survey in 2017 recruited more participants (652) however it took over one year. However, the study team did get the impression that there were significant numbers of MSM that were not being reached and that the number of workshops conducted by BCC officers were too few for the year. Facilities to host workshops usually needed to be rented and the budget seemed limited. Some peer recruiters were being paid as much as JMD5,000 per MSM whom they recruited for a workshop. We are of the view that this is far too much to pay and encourages a commercial or transactional arrangement instead of a public health approach. We used peer recruiters for this study only when we found it necessary and negotiated an incentive of JMD500 per MSM recruited. It appeared that peer contact at some sites was controlled by the recruiter, which provided the opportunity to make money. In some instances, participants alluded that it was not necessary to take appointment cards and invitation letters

as the recruiter would do the recruiting. The distribution of appointment cards and invitation letters to participants for them to invite their peers was not effective in those parishes.

### **HIV Treatment Cascade**

Most of the participants who were HIV positive in this survey were aware of their status and on ART which indicates that HIV testing appears to be readily available. While 80.6% of HIV positive MSM were virally suppressed only 68.2% of TGW were suppressed. This may be due to the significant stigma and discrimination faced by TGW. Persons who experienced adverse life events, were of lower SES or educational level or accepted money for sex were less likely to be virally suppressed. Their life challenges are greater.

### **Estimate of MSM and TGW population size**

The survey was unable to provide reliable estimates of the population size of MSM and TGW in Jamaica. Previous estimates of the MSM population have varied. The 876-study used different methods to estimate the MSM population in Jamaica including extrapolation from the literature – 46,613 (28,832 – 64,392) and wisdom of the crowd – 30,000 (20,000 – 30,000) (9). The Jamaica HIV National Strategic Plan for MSM 2012 estimated the MSM population in Jamaica as 33,000 (12) while the JASL Case Study on Comprehensive Clinical Services for MSM in Jamaica 2018 estimated a population of 42,400 (13). A meta-analysis of studies in the United States in 2012 estimated the size of the MSM population to be 3.9% (3.5% – 4.4%) of the US male population (14).

There are approximately 1,000,000 males aged 15 – 64 years in Jamaica in 2024. Therefore 3.9% - 4% gives an estimated 39,000 - 40,000 MSM in Jamaica including TGW who constitute a very small minority of the MSM. Given the hostility of many in Jamaica to MSM, and the more open attitude to MSM in the US, the proportion of the male population in Jamaica who are MSM may be somewhat smaller than in the US. The 876-study estimates that 34,705 (95% CI 33,163 – 36,080) males are likely to disclose as MSM in Jamaica. There are anecdotal reports of a significant number of MSM migrating from Jamaica including seeking asylum in Europe and North America. The reports of participants in the survey concerning the number of friends and peers who they know have migrated supports these anecdotal reports.

The 2020 WHO UNAIDS publication on recommended population size estimates for MSM notes that the median value for the Caribbean is 2.7% of the male population (15). Applying this value to Jamaica would give an estimate of 27,000 MSM. If we take into account the out migration of MSM from Jamaica an estimate of 25,000 MSM including TGW may be a reasonable guesstimate.

A strength of this study was that the recruitment process was consistent with the UNAIDS/WHO BBS-Lite method which recruits through NGOs and public health staff providing HIV prevention and other services and as a result have long standing relationships with the MSM and TGW communities. The swift completion of the survey with high quality control

was a significant achievement. By tracking recruitment carefully, we were able to analyse the data by strata and clusters and provide adjusted HIV prevalence with 95% Confidence Intervals and HIV prevalence ratios. The questionnaire was comprehensive so there is considerable data available to help guide the National HIV/STI Program.

It is very difficult to assess how representative a sample of the MSM and TGW populations was achieved. The number of TGW recruited was small (41). Our influential contacts within the TGW community informed us that many of the TGW were not comfortable doing the blood test and may have otherwise done the interview. Most participants were of lower or middle socio-economic status with few from the upper middle or upper class. There was no attempt to recruit from the private sector where little is known of how many MSM and TGW are under care.

## **Conclusion**

While there are encouraging signs such as the positive relationships and good services offered by the NGOs and many BCC officers and their teams, the sobering truth is that we are failing to achieve a significant reduction in the HIV incidence or prevalence among MSM and TGW. The most promising sign is that those MSM who ever used PrEP are less likely to be HIV infected. Clearly the use of PrEP must be expanded as a priority. Measures to promote post exposure prophylaxis are also needed (16). However, these approaches must be supported by innovative programs to address the psycho-social care of MSM and TGW of low socio-economic status.

While we recognize the progress made, we must continue to address barriers to prevention and care as well as stigma within our health services. Structural changes are needed to affirm the rights of MSM and TGW including changes in social and cultural norms. This includes the repeal or amendment of the Offences Against the Person Act of 1864. It is disheartening to witness the unacceptable high level of verbal and sexual abuse and beating that MSM and TGW receive as children and the high level of rape, homelessness and violence that they suffer as adults. We need, and must advocate and work for, decisive changes in the attitudes of our people and our social norms and structures to accept MSM and TGW as our children, brothers and sisters, friends and neighbours, and as humans deserving of the peace and love that we all yearn for and deserve.

## **RECOMMENDATIONS**

1. A clear priority of the National HIV/STI Program must be to get many more MSM and TGW using PrEP at a young age.
2. Bioline testing should be routinely offered to all MSM and young adults at Accident and Emergency departments of hospitals, inner city health centres and NGOs providing services to MSM and TGW.
3. A public education campaign to educate parents that beating and abusing children affects them negatively while praising good behaviour and expressing love for your child promotes self-esteem and appropriate behaviour.
4. Expand the early childhood stimulation program Reach Up to include all vulnerable children.
5. Establish more safe spaces for young MSM and TGW in schools and communities.
6. Train counselors in schools and communities to provide support and guidance to young MSM and TGW.
7. Develop training programs in areas such as personal growth and skill development to empower vulnerable MSM and TGW.
8. A system needs to be developed whereby persons seeking health services from NGO and public clinics are encouraged to present an ID to verify their name.
9. Continue the work to improve the quality of HIV treatment and care to MSM and TGW to achieve a higher proportion accessing anti-retroviral treatment and achieving viral load suppression.
10. Explore improving awareness of and access to post exposure prophylaxis (PEP).
11. Regional Health Authorities need to ensure that health staff have a suitable conference room to meet and conduct health promotion, prevention and training workshops and activities without the need to rent premises.
12. Support and advocate for continued funding to NGOs providing HIV prevention and other services and safe spaces for MSM and TGW.
13. Continue the work to reduce stigma and discrimination towards MSM and TGW in our health and other services.
14. Develop a closer relationship between the MOHW and Health Regions with private practitioners especially those who provide services for MSM and TGW.
15. Promote safe channels where MSM and TGW can report abuse, discrimination or violence and seek redress.
16. Challenge the religious communities to work more closely with, and provide services for, MSM and TG to better understand them and their needs.
17. Work to repeal or amend the Offences Against the Person Act of 1864 through the courts and through parliament.

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